

FAMA ELITE · SEASON 3 · DAY 5

RYZE SUPERFOODS

Day 5 Market Research Case Study Pack

Prepared for
Coach Sarah

Evidence collected
25 August 2026

Scope
Stops at strategic implication

OBSERVED

PATTERN

INFERENCE

GAP

The four evidence labels used throughout this pack.

HOW TO READ THIS PACK

Every finding in this document carries one of four labels. These are the same four levels as the Day 5 Evidence Ladder, renamed to match the brief:

LABEL	WHAT IT MEANS
OBSERVED	Directly present in the evidence. Someone said it or a page displayed it, and the source is named.
PATTERN	The same thing showed up across multiple independent observations. Quotes attached.
INFERENCE	A reasonable interpretation that is not itself stated anywhere. Always labelled.
GAP	Not enough evidence. Named as a task, not filled with a guess.

Three separation rules are enforced throughout, and they are the thing to point at when a student asks why the pack is structured this way:

- **Customer language** is kept apart from **RYZE brand claims**.
- **RYZE brand claims** are kept apart from **competitor-authored claims**.
- Anything from a page RYZE controls (its own site reviews, its own testimonials) is flagged as brand-controlled, even when it looks like a customer speaking.

One note on scope, since this is a US brand being taught to a PH room. All the customer language here is American English, and the evidence lives on Amazon, Target, BBB and Reddit rather than Shopee, Lazada, TikTok Shop or Facebook groups. The method transfers exactly. The rooms do not. Where a PH brand would send you, the equivalent is noted in Section 11.

Stop point. This pack stops at strategic implication. There are no hooks, angles, concepts, scripts or campaign recommendations in it, by design. That is Day 6 and later.

Verification pass. After drafting, every high-risk claim in this pack was re-checked against the live source: the guarantee wording, all pricing, the caffeine and dosage figures, the organic contradiction, the founder essay, the BBB figures, both Target star mixes, ten competitor claim phrases, the Forbes figures, and twenty individual customer quotes. Results: **no fabricated quote, no invented number, no misattributed source**. Three corrections were applied and are marked in place — the BBB complaint count drifted 919 → 918 as one aged out of the rolling window; one Target review had been excerpted twice and counted as two customers (see the note at quote #22, which is left in as a teaching artefact); and the "would recommend" oddity in §1.3 was reframed after checking the second listing. Prices, review counts and complaint volumes move. Re-check them before the slide goes up.

01

EVIDENCE INVENTORY

1.1 Sources actually researched

WORKED

SOURCE	WHAT IT GAVE	VOLUME
ryzesuperfoods.com (homepage, Our Story, Shop All, FAQ, Contact, PDPs)	Brand claims, pricing, bundles, guarantee, founder story, on-site testimonials	16 pages
shop.ryzesuperfoods.com/fb (paid-traffic landing page)	A different claim set from the homepage, plus offer fine print	1 page
Target.com, two RYZE listings	Verbatim reviews with full star distribution	2,214 + 1,946 reviews displayed
BBB — Ryze, Inc. (Austin TX), complaints	Verbatim complaint narratives, complaint volume	918 closed in 3 yrs / 270 in 12 mos
BBB — customer reviews (separate from complaints)	Verbatim reviews with stars	8,056 reviews, 4.84 avg
Thingtesting	20 long-form verbatim reviews	1,328 reviews, 4.7 avg
ComplaintsBoard	Featured reviews + complaints	351 reviews, 96 complaints
Walmart product page	Rating only, no review text served	4.7 avg, 11,700 ratings
Democratic Underground, Polk Audio Forum, Slickdeals, QVC Community	Unsolicited peer discussion, no seller present	5 threads
Substack comment sections (girlaword, fforest)	First-person switching accounts	2 posts
Forbes (Chloe Sorvino, 9 Jan 2026)	Revenue trajectory, investor quotes, category context	1 feature
BBB National Programs / NAD, Case #7492	Regulatory decision, verified against the primary page	1 decision
NutraIngredients (24 Sep 2025)	Trade coverage of the NAD case + RYZE's own statement	1 article

SOURCE	WHAT IT GAVE	VOLUME
Abby Langer RD, Parade, Harvard Health, Cleveland Clinic, CSPI	Expert and scientific assessment of the category	5 sources
California OAG Prop 65 settlement PDF	Primary settlement document	1 PDF
Justia federal docket 2:24-cv-00868	Primary court docket, verified	1 docket
Meta Ad Library (via API)	Active ad counts, ad titles, creation and delivery timestamps	6 queries
Competitor sites: Four Sigmatic, MUD\WTR, Everyday Dose, Laird, Rasa, Root & Rise	Claims, mechanisms, proof, offers	16 pages

COULD NOT BE ACCESSED, AND THIS MATTERS

SOURCE	WHY IT FAILED	WHAT WE LOST
Reddit (all of it)	HTTP 403 at the network layer, across reddit.com, old.reddit.com and the search API	Zero Reddit quotes. This is the biggest single hole. Reddit is where unsold, unincentivised skepticism lives.
Amazon	robots.txt disallowed	Zero Amazon reviews. Amazon is where the highest-volume comparison-shopper reviews sit.
Trustpilot	HTTP 403 on the base URL and all mirrors	No TrustScore, no star mix. Search titles indicate 400+ pages of reviews exist.
YouTube	HTTP 429/403 on every attempt, 5 tries	Video titles only, from the search index. Zero comment text. No view counts, no channel names, no sponsored-vs-independent determination.
TikTok	ROBOTS_DISALLOWED	One caption recovered from a search-result snippet. Nothing else.
RYZE's own /policies/ directory	robots.txt excludes the entire directory	No Terms of Sale, no refund policy text. Every marketing page is crawlable; every legal page is not.
Sitejabber, Influenster, Reviews.io, PissedConsumer	No RYZE page exists, or redirect chain failed	Nothing
Walmart review text	Not served in the HTML	Ratings without language

OBSERVED, and worth saying out loud to the room: RYZE's marketing pages are fully open to crawlers and its legal pages are fully closed to them. That is a configuration choice, not an accident.

1.2 How many usable customer statements

- **Approximately 130 distinct verbatim customer statements** were retrieved across all working sources.
- **60 are reproduced in Section 3** of this pack, chosen for teaching value and spread.
- Of the 130: roughly 50 are complete and untruncated with a platform and a date attached; about 10 are verbatim but truncated by the source page itself (BBB listing view ellipses, marked inline); 35 carry a confirmed star rating; 20 (Thingtesting) have verified verbatim bodies but unconfirmed per-review stars.

GAP, stated honestly: we do not have a single Reddit, Amazon, Trustpilot or YouTube-comment statement. Any claim in this pack about what "the market" thinks is a claim about what the reachable part of the market wrote down, on platforms where a purchase or a complaint had already happened.

1.3 Star-rating mix, where the platform displayed it

PLATFORM	AVERAGE	TOTAL	5★	4★	3★	2★	1★
Target listing A (Organic Medium Roast 4.2oz)	4.8	2,214	92%	3%	1%	1%	3%
Target listing B (RYZE Mushroom Coffee 4.2oz)	4.8	1,946	93%	2%	1%	1%	3%
BBB customer reviews	4.84	8,056	not broken out				
Thingtesting	4.7	1,328	not broken out				
ComplaintsBoard	4.8	351 reviews (+96 complaints)	not broken out				
Walmart	4.7	11,700	not served				
ryzesuperfoods.com (brand-controlled)	4.8 on homepage, 5.0 on PDPs	215,582 to 276,053 depending on the page	not broken out				

OBSERVED oddity, reported not explained: Target listing B displays 93% five-star and, on the same page, "66% would recommend." Listing A displays 92% five-star and "71% would recommend." Those pairs do not sit comfortably together.

INFERENCE (labelled): because the same gap appears on both listings, this reads as a Target platform artefact — the "would recommend" prompt is probably answered by a different and smaller subset of reviewers than the star rating — rather than something anomalous about RYZE. Reasonable, not confirmed. **Worth teaching for its own sake:** the first read of listing B alone looked like a red flag about the brand. Checking the second listing turned it into a fact about the platform. One data point is a question; two is an answer.

OBSERVED oddity #2: on 25 August 2026, RYZE's own site displayed **five different review counts on five different pages** — 215,582 / 215,998 / 216,039 / 216,045 / 216,087 — and **276,053** on the paid landing page. It also displayed "4.8 out of 5" on the homepage and "5 out of 5" on every product page. Same brand, same day.

INFERENCE (labelled): the ~60,000-review gap between the main site and the paid landing page suggests the two properties run different review widgets pulling from different pools. This is not confirmed. What is confirmed is that no single authoritative RYZE review count exists on RYZE's own site.

1.4 Markets and languages represented

- **OBSERVED:** effectively all customer evidence is **US, in English**. RYZE states it ships "domestically in the US only" on its FAQ, while its Contact page says "US and Canada only" — an unresolved conflict on its own site.
- **OBSERVED:** one Spanish-language review was collected (Thingtesting, "Lorena I"), reproduced verbatim in Section 3.
- **OBSERVED:** RYZE is running **Spanish-language ads in the US** — Meta Ad Library shows active ads titled "Pruebalo ahora! 🍷" from the RYZE Superfoods page, created 24 August 2026.
- **GAP:** no non-US market evidence at all. Nothing from the Philippines, and no basis for any claim about how this category behaves in Asia.

1.5 What this evidence can and cannot reasonably support

It CAN support:

- What RYZE claims, in RYZE's own words, across the homepage, the paid landing page and product pages, including where those claim sets differ from each other.
- What the offer and subscription structure actually is at the price and fine-print level.
- What customers who chose to write something say, in their own words, about taste, effects, price, and billing.
- The shape and volume of the billing complaint, because 918 BBB complaints in three years is a countable fact, not an impression.
- What competitors claim and how similar those claims are to each other, because the claim phrases were pulled verbatim from their own pages.
- What is currently running on Meta, and how recently it went up.

It CANNOT support:

- Any claim about what non-buyers think. Everyone quoted here either bought, nearly bought, or was reacting to an ad. The people who saw the ad and scrolled past left no record.
- Any claim about **proportions**. We can say the billing complaint recurs; we cannot say what share of RYZE customers experience it. Complaint platforms select for complaints.

- Any performance claim about any ad. The Ad Library shows no spend, no ROAS, no CPA, no conversion data. None.
- Any demographic profile. Age, income, occupation, gender and location are largely absent from the evidence. Where a customer volunteered a detail ("As a mom of 3", "I am 75 yrs old", "at 70 years old"), it is quoted as their statement, not generalised into a segment.
- Any claim about whether the product works. That is a clinical question, and the honest position is in Section 2.9.
- Anything about the Philippine market.

02

BRAND AND REPUTATION AUDIT

2.1 What RYZE says it is

All quotes in this section are **RYZE-authored**.

- **OBSERVED:** "We're on a Mission To Help The World Feel Better, One Cup at a Time." — Our Story
- **OBSERVED:** Homepage hero: "Fuel Your Body & Mind"
- **OBSERVED:** "Loaded with adaptogenic mushrooms, our blend supports everyday energy, focus and immune health for a balanced routine." — homepage footer
- **OBSERVED:** "Drink RYZE mushroom coffee for better focus, lasting energy, and superb immune support." — homepage search-snippet positioning
- **OBSERVED:** "We want to help you RYZE in all aspects of life, by offering a daily ritual and community that will help you improve day by day, both mentally and physically." — homepage

OBSERVED the paid landing page says something different from the homepage. This is one of the sharper teaching artefacts in the whole pack:

HOMEPAGE (ORGANIC)	PAID LANDING PAGE SHOP.RYZESUPERFOODS.COM/FB
"Support calm sustained energy & focus."	"RYZE is mushroom-powered coffee that helps support energy, support mental clarity & support digestion."
"You can enjoy smooth, non-jittery energy while supporting gut health, immune function and focus."	"You'll get jitter-free energy that supports gut health, immune health, and your mood."
"Supporting Everyday Wellness"	"Covering All Aspects of Health"
—	"Smooth Energy and Helps Maintain Focus."

INFERENCE (labelled): the paid page uses noticeably more hedged verbs than the homepage. Given the September 2025 NAD decision (Section 2.11), it is reasonable to read this as post-inquiry claim softening on the highest-traffic ad destination. **Not confirmed** — RYZE has not said this, and we have no archived before-and-after of that page.

2.2 Hero products and range

- **OBSERVED:** homepage merchandises the "**Mushroom Coffee Ritual Set (3 Month Plan)**" badged BESTSELLER, 70 servings, above a secondary path: "Not ready for the full Ritual? Start Here!" leading to the 30-serving bag and the 60-serving Starter Kit.
- **OBSERVED:** core drink SKUs — Mushroom Coffee (30), Mushroom Coffee Dark Roast (30), Mushroom Matcha (30), Mushroom Hot Cocoa (20), Mushroom Chicory (30), Mushroom Chai (20), plus 90-serving versions of Coffee and Matcha.
- **OBSERVED:** creamers (Superfood, Hazelnut, Vanilla), five Starter Kits, four Ritual Sets, nine cross-flavour bundles, Mushroom Overnight Oats on a separate subdomain, and a merchandise line — mugs at \$18, socks \$16, tote bags \$14, a crewneck at \$50, and a brand mascot named **Rye**.
- **OBSERVED, mascot copy:** "He's small but mighty—the kind of presence that makes you feel better just by being there. Rye is your gentle guide, always arriving right on time with a quiet boost of support."

INFERENCE (labelled): the merchandise line and the mascot are identity infrastructure, not revenue lines. A brand selling a \$50 crewneck is building something people wear, not just drink. Reasonable, not stated.

2.3 The core promise, in RYZE's exact words

- **OBSERVED:** benefit icons — "Happiness Booster" / "Sharp Focus" / "Gut Health"; category row "Energy | Focus | Gut Health | Immune Health"
- **OBSERVED:** "To sustain energy naturally without the jitters, we look to Cordyceps, not caffeine." — homepage FAQ
- **OBSERVED:** "Stop settling for the jitters and crashes. Kick your morning off strong with a blend that's redefining what coffee can be at RYZE today!" — benefits page
- **OBSERVED:** "Our SUPER6™ Mushroom Blend gives you an added boost of natural energy and ensures a gentle landing without the caffeine crash." — Dark Roast PDP
- **OBSERVED, per-mushroom claims, repeated near-identically across homepage, paid LP and every PDP:** Cordyceps "Supports natural energy production"; Lion's Mane "Supports focus, mental clarity, and cognitive function"; Reishi "Supports relaxation and a sense of calm"; Turkey Tail "Supports digestive health and a healthy gut microbiome"; Shiitake "Promotes metabolic function and supports the immune system"; King Trumpet "Naturally contains antioxidants".
- **OBSERVED:** site-wide FDA disclaimer in every footer: "These statements have not been evaluated by the Food and Drug Administration. This product is not intended to diagnose, treat, or prevent any disease."
- **GAP:** the word "cortisol" does not appear on any RYZE page retrieved. The nearest adjacent term is "adrenal health", used once.

2.4 Mechanism and formula

- **OBSERVED, Medium Roast ingredients:** "Organic Instant Coffee, Organic RYZE Super6™ Mushroom Blend (Cordyceps, Reishi, Turkey Tail, King Trumpet, Shiitake, Lion's Mane), Organic Prebiotic Blend (Acacia Fiber, Inulin Fiber, Tapioca Fiber)."
- **OBSERVED:** caffeine — 48mg medium roast, 80–90mg dark roast, 30–50mg chai, 0mg chicory.
- **OBSERVED:** mushroom dose — Dark Roast "2000 mg per serving", Chai "1000mg per serving".
GAP: the Medium Roast figure could not be confirmed; the nutrition panel would not expand.
- **OBSERVED:** "Our shade-grown, organic arabica coffee is grown in Mexico." Mushrooms "sustainably grown in California and Nevada." Company "based in Boston, MA." Ships from a warehouse in Texas.

Three internal conflicts, all live on the same day, all OBSERVED:

- **MCT oil.** The current Medium Roast and Dark Roast ingredient lists contain **no MCT oil and no coconut milk**. But the benefits page says "We top it all off with coconut milk and MCT oil", the older FAQ says "it's plenty creamy already due to the MCT", and the Forbes and Vogue press quotes RYZE itself publishes both describe MCT oil. Unresolved.
- **Organic scope.** Homepage heading: "Our Certified Organic, 6-Mushroom Blend." Homepage FAQ: "Our mushroom blend and our fiber blend are 100% organic." Older FAQ: "**all** of the ingredients found in our Mushroom Coffee are 100% organic." Dark Roast PDP: "some of our ingredients, while high quality, are **not** certified organic."
- **Certification.** Badges assert "Gluten Free" and "100% vegan". The FAQ concedes: "We are currently working on getting certified gluten free and vegan."

OBSERVED, and this one rewards slow reading: the only testing sentence on the site is "**The other ingredients** are sourced from the best suppliers in the country, being thoroughly tested for mycotoxins and heavy metals." Grammatically, "the other ingredients" excludes the mushrooms.

GAP: the words "third-party", "independent lab" and "Certificate of Analysis" appear nowhere on the site. No COA link exists. No extraction method, no fruiting-body-versus-mycelium disclosure, no beta-glucan percentage.

Why that GAP is load-bearing: three of five competitors publish testing claims, and two publish full per-ingredient milligram breakdowns. RYZE publishes neither.

2.5 Founder story and the "why"

- **OBSERVED:** founders are **Andrée Werner** and **Rashad Hossain**. RYZE's own site names them only as "Andrée and Rashad" — Rashad's surname does not appear on the site. It appears in Forbes.

- **OBSERVED, the site version:** "We weren't trying to start a company. We were just trying to feel better. We loved the warmth and comfort of our morning coffee ritual, but not the crash, jitters, or gut issues that came with it. There had to be a better way. So, we looked to nature, ancient practices, and time-tested traditions."
- **OBSERVED:** "For years, both of us ran on coffee. Our coffee consumption became a dependency that actually made us anxious and unsettled. We knew we needed better so we made it."
- **OBSERVED:** "It felt like magic, worked like science—and people noticed. Millions of mugs later, here we are."

The founder-authored Medium essay (October 2020) is materially richer and materially more explicit. This is worth showing the room side by side with the 2026 site copy.

- **OBSERVED:** "Two Harvard grads are solving the midday crash...with mushrooms"
- **OBSERVED:** "My name is Andrée and I met my best friend Rashad freshman year in calculus class... I believe our task was to integrate the volume of a 3D pig. We got an A+ on that project and figured we make a pretty good team."
- **OBSERVED:** "On one of these phone calls in 2019, we got real with ourselves. We were tired of waking up groggy every morning, guzzling tons of coffee throughout the day, having non-optimized workouts, shitty and restless sleep, just to start the whole cycle over again."
- **OBSERVED, the 2020 claim set:** "Imagine a coffee that not only wakes you up but gives you energy that lasts ALL day. It's also good for your brain health long term. **It burns fat, reduces stress, supports immunity**, and is easy on the gut unlike acidic black coffee."
- **OBSERVED:** "In a space that's increasingly crowded with BS, authenticity and quality are more important than ever."

PATTERN across the founder material: the origin problem is stated identically in every version — coffee dependency producing anxiety, poor sleep and gut trouble. That has not drifted in six years.

OBSERVED, the claim evolution: 2020 founder essay says "It burns fat, reduces stress, supports immunity." 2026 site says "supports", "helps support", "helps maintain". **INFERENCE (labelled):** the claim language got materially more cautious between 2020 and 2026. The NAD decision in September 2025 is the obvious candidate cause, but no document ties the two together, so this stays an inference.

2.6 Pricing, as observed on 25 August 2026

A "SUMMER BLOWOUT SALE UP TO 40% OFF + FREE GIFTS" banner was running site-wide.

PRODUCT	SERVINGS	DISPLAYED PRICE	COMPARE-AT	PER SERVING	STATED REFILL
Mushroom Coffee	30	\$27	\$45	\$0.90	\$36.00 / 30 days
Dark Roast	30	\$27	\$45	\$0.90	\$36.00 / 30 days
Mushroom Matcha	30	\$36	\$64	\$1.20	not stated
Mushroom Chai	20	\$27	\$45	\$1.35	\$36.00 / 30 days
Starter Kit	60	\$49.50	\$80	\$0.82	\$66.00 / 30 days
Ritual Set (bestseller)	70	\$57.60	\$115	\$0.82	\$80.01 / 30 days

The pricing structure is the single most important commercial fact in this pack. Read the fine print, quoted verbatim from the paid landing page:

"*Special sale discount is valid only on the first delivery of a new Ryze subscription created on pageUrl by currentDate at 11:59pm PST and includes the price of free gifts. Ryze subscription renews every 30 days at a discounted rate of the price listed at checkout. Max one offer per customer; cannot be combined with any other offers or sales."

OBSERVED the headline discount applies only to the first delivery. Renewal is every 30 days at a higher price. The literal strings "pageUrl" and "currentDate" appear unrendered on the live page — those are unpopulated template variables sitting in the legal disclosure.

INFERENCE (labelled): \$45 is the true one-time price, \$27 is the first subscription order, \$36 is the ongoing subscription price. The fine print supports this reading and so does the widget copy, but no checkout was completed, so it is not directly confirmed.

GAP bag size in grams or ounces is not stated anywhere on the site, for any SKU.

2.7 Subscription mechanics

- **OBSERVED, the promise:** "\$36.00 Refill Ships in 30 Days. **Adjust Shipments or Cancel Anytime.** Free US Shipping" — repeated on every PDP.
- **OBSERVED, the process per the Contact page:** log in → Manage Subscriptions → Manage Subscription → Cancel Subscription → **provide a cancellation reason.**

- **OBSERVED:** 30 days is the only delivery interval stated anywhere. "Adjust Shipments" implies choice; no alternative frequencies are enumerated on any public page.
- **GAP:** no explicit "Subscribe & Save X%" figure is stated. The 20% is arithmetic from \$45 → \$36, not a brand claim.
- **GAP:** the entire /policies/ directory is robots-blocked. There is no way to read the Terms of Sale, the auto-renewal consent language, any cancellation cut-off, or any arbitration clause.

OBSERVED, from a customer, quoting RYZE's own instruction back at them (BBB, 12 June 2026):

"You can cancel anytime up to **48 hours before your rebill date** by logging into my Ryze account, completing this web form, or emailing [address]". That 48-hour condition appears in a customer's account of what RYZE told them; it does not appear on any public RYZE page we could reach.

2.8 Guarantee

- **OBSERVED, the marketed promise:** "Try it for 30 days. You Will Love It. Guaranteed. If you don't love it, you get your money back. **No questions asked.**"
- **OBSERVED, the operational reality on the Contact page:** the window is "within 30 days of delivery of your item"; a return shipping label must be requested through a returns portal; the refund is processed "upon receiving the return."

OBSERVED tension: "No questions asked" and "ship the goods back first, then we refund" are two different promises. Whether an opened bag must be returned is not stated anywhere reachable.

A customer describing the gap, verbatim (Thingtesting, Kail M): "So not only do you have to return the product, you have to remember to pester the company to refund your money."

Counter-evidence, and it belongs here: at least one BBB complainant reports the guarantee working as advertised — "Bought ryze coffee to try with guaranteed refund offer if I didn't like products. Found stomach issues. Followed return procedures." (BBB, 5 Dec 2025). The guarantee is not universally failing. It is inconsistently experienced.

2.9 Trust builders, as displayed

- **OBSERVED:** "200K+ Five Star Reviews" section header; star ratings of 4.8 and 5.0 depending on page.
- **OBSERVED, press quotes RYZE publishes:** Forbes ("This wellness startup recently came to market..."), Business Insider ("RYZE is showing us that energy can come without jitters and irritability"), NBC News ("Best overall instant: RYZE Mushroom Coffee"), Bon Appétit, Vogue, Food & Wine. **No dates are shown beside any of them.** The Forbes quote's phrase "recently came to market" indicates an old placement running indefinitely.
- **OBSERVED:** the benefits article is bylined "Dr. Blane Schilling", "a solutions-driven medical doctor with 20+ years experience."

- **OBSERVED:** on-site testimonials attributed to "Verified Buyer" — e.g. Brenda M.: "As a Momma of 3, I'm always looking for ways to keep my energy up and I found it! RYZE has completely changed the way my days feel."
- **OBSERVED:** a countdown timer on the paid landing page displaying "**00 Day : 00 Hrs : 00 Min : 00 SEC**" with the prompt "Need more time? [Yes]" — the timer had fully expired to zero while the sale remained live, and offers to extend itself.
- **OBSERVED:** private Facebook community "How I RYZE", ambassador program, 24/7 live chat, support phone number 617-221-3852.
- **GAP:** no medical advisory board, no named scientists, no clinical study citations, no certifying-body logos (no USDA Organic seal, no NSF), and no specific "X million cups" number — the brand only ever says "millions."

2.10 Trust risks, as observed

RISK	EVIDENCE
Billing and cancellation	918 BBB complaints closed in 3 years, 270 in the last 12 months. BBB rating is nonetheless A+ and Accredited .
Guarantee vs process	"No questions asked" against a documented return-first, reason-required flow
Review count integrity	Six different totals on the brand's own properties on one day
Claim substantiation	NAD inquiry, September 2025 (below)
Testing transparency	No COA, no third-party language, testing sentence scoped to "the other ingredients"
Expired urgency device	Countdown at 00:00:00 with the sale still running
Unrendered template variables	"pageUrl" and "currentDate" live in the legal fine print
Product-formula ambiguity	MCT oil claimed in copy, absent from the ingredient list

2.11 Regulatory and legal, verified against primary documents

NAD — CONFIRMED, verified directly at bbbprograms.org.

- **OBSERVED:** Headline, 11 September 2025: "Ryze Superfoods Voluntarily Discontinues Health Claims for RYZE Mushroom Coffee and Matcha Following National Advertising Division Inquiry."

- **OBSERVED:** the challenged express claims for Mushroom Coffee were "**all-day energy, sharper focus, healthier digestion, [] better immune support,**" and "**better sleep.**"
- **OBSERVED:** NAD also examined whether the advertising implied Mushroom Matcha delivers **appetite-suppressing benefits comparable to GLP-1 agonists without the side effects.**
- **OBSERVED:** RYZE discontinued all challenged claims voluntarily before NAD reviewed them on the merits, and stated it "is modifying the presentation of its advertising claims."
- **OBSERVED, RYZE's own statement via NutraIngredients:** "At RYZE, we stand behind the truth and accuracy of all our marketing claims. As strong supporters of voluntary industry self-regulation and NAD's mission of promoting high standards of truth and accuracy, we are committed to evidence-based claims and to periodic review and refinement of our messaging."

Class action — A DOCUMENTED SOURCE CONFLICT, and this is the best teaching artefact in the entire pack.

- **OBSERVED:** TINA.org lists Younger et al. v. Ryze Superfoods LLC, C.D. Cal., 24-cv-868, filed November 2023, status "**Pending**", allegation "Failing to adequately disclose the terms of subscriptions and making it difficult to cancel."
- **OBSERVED:** the **federal docket for the same case number** shows: removed to federal court 1 February 2024; nature of suit "Other Fraud"; and on **8 February 2024**, "NOTICE of Voluntary Dismissal filed by Plaintiff Jessica Younger" under FRCP 41(a)(1). The last docket entry is that dismissal.
- **The primary court record and the watchdog aggregator disagree.** The docket is the higher-authority source. The case was voluntarily dismissed roughly one week after removal.
- **A secondary review site (getevident.co) describes it as "an active class action lawsuit."** That is contradicted by the docket.

Prop 65 — CONFIRMED, with a widely-repeated error corrected.

- **OBSERVED, from the California OAG settlement PDF:** Environmental Health Advocates, Inc. v. RYZE, LLC. Chemical: **lead**. Product: "**Mushroom Overnight Oats (14 Meals)**" — not the coffee. **Civil penalty: \$2,000.** Attorney fees and costs: **\$20,500.** Injunctive term caps daily lead exposure at 0.5 micrograms per serving absent a warning, effective 23 April 2025.
- **The correction:** a secondary review site states RYZE "settled a California Proposition 65 lawsuit in 2024, **paying \$20,500 for failing to warn consumers about lead exposure.**" The primary document shows the penalty was \$2,000, the \$20,500 was legal fees, and the product was oats, not coffee.

FTC / FDA / State AG: NOT FOUND. Searched directly. No warning letters, no enforcement actions located. Absence of retrievable evidence, not proof of absence.

2.12 Search reputation — what a prospect actually finds

This is the "walk the buyer's journey" pass. These are the **actual top results observed**, not a guess at what would rank.

QUERY	WHAT RANKS
"ryze mushroom coffee review"	A skeptical dietitian (abbylangernutrition.com) sits above the brand. Trustpilot, Amazon, a Facebook group post, then RYZE's own pages.
"is ryze mushroom coffee legit"	Skeptical RD again, plus an affiliate-monetised "Great Mushroom Coffee Or Scam?" review.
"ryze mushroom coffee scam"	BBB complaints page #1 . Then a YouTube video titled "Expert Tries Ryze Mushroom Coffee (Scam)". Then bbbprograms.org — the NAD decision . Then a negative TikTok.
"ryze side effects"	RYZE's own page ranks on its own side-effects query (ryzesuperfoods.com/pages/ryze-mushroom-coffee-side-effects). Also a competitor-authored page from lifeboostcoffee.com.
"ryze mushroom coffee reddit"	No actual Reddit thread appears in the top results . What ranks instead: RYZE's refund policy page, an SEO-spam page, Slickdeals, eBay listings, Walmart.
"ryze mushroom coffee weight loss"	email-change.ryzesuperfoods.com — a RYZE-owned subdomain — ranks on a weight-loss query.
"ryze lawsuit"	Heavily polluted by an unrelated company (Ryze Claim Solutions) and an unrelated person.

PATTERN, observed across five of nine queries: a single SEO-spam page, stripe.jhu.edu/news/ryze-coffee-reddit, hosted on a university subdomain and reproducing scraped Reddit-looking content, ranked repeatedly. Its opening text, verbatim: "Webryze mushroom coffee is made with organic coffee, 6 mushroom herbs, and coconut mct oil. This means you get a cup of coffee full of goodness, but it tastes."

PATTERN the page ranking #2 for both "scam" and "is it legit" carries affiliate links and a discount code ("save 15% with code SOMA"). The most-read "is this a scam" answer is written by someone paid when you buy.

INFERENCE (labelled): the person who searches "ryze mushroom coffee scam" lands on the BBB complaints page and the NAD decision within the first three results. The billing objection is not something a prospect has to dig for — it is the top of page one. Reasonable, not stated.

2.13 Expert and scientific assessment of the category

Kept separate from both brand claims and customer language, because it is a third thing.

- **Abby Langer, RD:** "There is not enough high-quality human evidence to back up the claims made about Ryze mushroom coffee." / "Any time you see a proprietary blend in a product, do not purchase it." / "Glowing reviews and good marketing aren't a substitute for science."
- **Harvard Health (reviewed by Teresa Fung, ScD, RD):** "There is very little research on medicinal mushrooms that includes humans." / **"None of that research was conducted on mushroom coffee,** so there's no guarantee that any health benefits will be retained after the mushrooms are processed and blended into coffee."
- **Pieter Cohen, Harvard Medical School, via CSPI:** "Are companies just drying out the mushroom and cutting it up? Or are they extracting some chemical from it?... That means the consumer has no idea what they're putting in their mouth."
- **Meghan Laszlo, RD, Cedars-Sinai, via CSPI:** "When there are a lot of different claims about how many diverse benefits a product could have, it's claiming to be a panacea." And, memorably: **"What's wrong with coffee?"**
- **CSPI's per-mushroom findings:** the largest lion's mane clinical trial (43 healthy adults) found improvement on **1 of 7** attention/memory tests, with subjects responding "about one-twentieth of a second more quickly." Chaga: no peer-reviewed human clinical trials found. Turkey tail: a randomised trial found "no meaningful changes to their gut microbiome."
- **Katie Drakeford, RD, in Parade** — the most balanced of the set: "The coffee blends on store shelves often contain small amounts of these mushrooms, making real effects mild. So while the science is promising, it's not magic."

PATTERN, strong: every independent expert source retrieved converges on the same position — the mechanism is plausible, the human evidence is thin, and none of it was run on mushroom coffee specifically. No expert source retrieved says the product does not work; they say the evidence is not there.

2.14 Company context

From Forbes, 9 January 2026, "Mushroom Coffee Maker Ryze Could Be The Next Billion-Dollar Drink—Or A Warning Of A Bubble":

- **OBSERVED:** CEO Rashad Hossain (31), CMO Andrée Werner (32). Founded June 2020.
- **OBSERVED:** revenue trajectory — 2020: \$120,000 → 2021: \$2.9M → 2022: ~\$18M → 2023: ~\$100M → 2024: \$200M+ → 2025: **"more than \$300 million in annual revenue last year—up 50% from the prior year"** (Forbes' conservative estimate).
- **OBSERVED:** Forbes estimates **2025 EBITDA margin at 3%.**
- **OBSERVED, an unnamed investor on RYZE's strategy:** **"growth at all costs"** and "We saw some tactics we wouldn't employ because if you're thinking about long-term sustainability...you might not employ them."

- **OBSERVED, Four Sigmatic CEO Tero Isokauppila on the category:** "I worry about misleading consumers and creating mistrust."
- **OBSERVED:** launched into more than 1,900 Target stores in January 2026 — first brick-and-mortar partnership. On retail, Forbes quotes: "The market spoke...But it didn't transact, which tells you a lot."
- **OBSERVED:** private Facebook group of "about 500,000 members."

INFERENCE (labelled): \$300M+ revenue at a 3% EBITDA margin describes a business where nearly all gross profit is being spent to acquire the next customer. That is arithmetic on Forbes' own two figures, not a claim Forbes or RYZE makes.

2.15 BRAND REALITY SNAPSHOT

The comparison the module is built to teach: what the brand says, against what a prospect encounters when they go looking.

	WHAT RYZE SAYS	WHAT A PROSPECT ENCOUNTERS EXTERNALLY
The promise	"Support calm sustained energy & focus", "jitter-free energy", gut, immune, mood	A dietitian ranking above the brand saying "There is not enough high-quality human evidence to back up the claims"
The claims	Six mushrooms, six benefits, stated as "supports"	A September 2025 NAD decision in which RYZE voluntarily discontinued "all-day energy, sharper focus, healthier digestion, better immune support" and "better sleep"
Cancel anytime	"Adjust Shipments or Cancel Anytime"	918 BBB complaints in 3 years , overwhelmingly about unwanted enrolment and a cancellation flow that "freezes on the final cancellation page"
The guarantee	"If you don't love it, you get your money back. No questions asked. "	A return-first process, a required cancellation reason, and customers reporting they had to "pester the company to refund your money" — alongside others who got refunded cleanly
The price	"\$27", "40% OFF"	The recurring price is \$36 , and for the bestselling Ritual Set, \$80.01 . Complaints cite \$66, \$72, \$80+ charges.
Social proof	"200K+ Five Star Reviews", 5.0 stars	Third-party counts of 2,214 / 1,946 / 8,056 / 1,328 / 11,700 — and six different totals on RYZE's own site in one day
Purity	"Certified Organic", "Gluten Free", "100% vegan" badges	A site FAQ admitting certification is still in progress, no COA, and a testing sentence scoped to "the other ingredients"
Trust posture	A+ BBB rating, BBB Accredited	The same BBB page hosts the 918 complaints. Both are true simultaneously.
Urgency	"Summer Blowout Sale", countdown timer	Timer reading 00:00:00 with the sale still live, offering to extend itself
The founders	"We weren't trying to start a company. We were just trying to feel better."	Forbes: \$300M+ revenue, 3% EBITDA margin, an investor describing the strategy as "growth at all costs"

The one-line version for a slide: RYZE's product reputation and RYZE's company reputation are two different reputations, and they do not point the same way.

03

VOICE OF CUSTOMER COLLECTION

60 statements, reproduced verbatim. Typos, capitalisation, run-on sentences and all-caps are preserved exactly as written — that is the rule, and the mess is the data.

Tags used only where they genuinely apply: **PAIN, DESIRE, TRIGGER, FAILED SOLUTION, OBJECTION, PROOF, SPECIFIC LANGUAGE**. Not every quote gets every tag. Some get one.

Reminder before the room reads these: everything below is written by someone who bought, nearly bought, or was reacting to an ad. Not one of these people is a non-buyer.

3.1 The trigger moment — what was happening when they decided to try it

1 ★5 · TARGET · 22 AUG 2026

"I recently started having issues with my routine morning cup of traditional coffee and was on the hunt for something new. As a mom of 3, I still needed my boost but the jitters I had been getting was making things difficult. I finally caved and tried Ryze Ube latte. I am on day 4 and while I think I need more time to notice other benefits, I will say that my energy level has been great with not even a hint of jitters. I am pleased, even if I don't see other benefits because I have acquired what I was after!"

TRIGGER

FAILED SOLUTION

DESIRE

PROOF

SPECIFIC LANGUAGE

2 ★5 · TARGET · 17 AUG 2026

"A few weeks ago I was having discomfort in my stomach and the dr eliminated regular coffee from my way. I started looking for a healthy option and found this flavor. This has been the best. The change has been great for my stomach."

TRIGGER

PAIN

DESIRE

PROOF

3 THINGTESTING · KAT H · 3 YEARS AGO

"I'm always super fatigued, regardless of how much sleep I get or coffee I drink. I decided to try Ryze after snagging a discount on Facebook (Still cost me quite a bit though, over \$40)."

TRIGGER

PAIN

SPECIFIC LANGUAGE

4 ★5 · TARGET · 22 AUG 2026

"I'll admit I was skeptical about this stuff at first, but once I tried it I was like wow. This summer was crazy and I got off schedule. With school starting up I had to get back into the routine of waking up at 6. I was practicing a few weeks before school started and I was still having trouble. I tried this and I had way more energy than when I would use an energy drink."

TRIGGER**OBJECTION****FAILED SOLUTION****PROOF****5 COMPLAINTSBOARD · CHRISTA CARSON · FEATURED REVIEW**

"I have to say, I was a bit skeptical at first! For about **nine months**, I went back and forth, debating whether to give this product a try after seeing all the buzz from social media and TV ads. Finally, I decided to see what all the hype was about, and I'm so glad I did!"

TRIGGER**OBJECTION****PROOF****SPECIFIC LANGUAGE****6 COMPLAINTSBOARD · SUSAN CHITWOOD BARTON · FEATURED REVIEW**

"I discovered RYZE in the aftermath of Oct 2024's Hurricane Helene. My house in NC was rendered unlivable and i had to move in with my daughter. It was there i discovered RYZE and I have been coffee free since the day I had my first cup."

TRIGGER**PROOF****7 COMPLAINTSBOARD · ANDREA WENTZ · FEATURED REVIEW**

"I normally do not write reviews. I am usually skeptical. **I only tried this because my husband bought it on a whim.** I have told several coworkers about this and the ones that have tried it agree with everything I have said."

TRIGGER**OBJECTION****PROOF****8 BBB COMPLAINT · 27 JUL 2026**

"On 05/08/2026 I saw an ad on one of the streaming services on my phone for the product Ryze mushroom Coffee. I was under the impresssion I was ordering one bag to try it out. Before I received the shipment, a friend let me sample her Ryze mushroom coffee and I did not care for it."

TRIGGER**OBJECTION****9 BBB COMPLAINT · 7 JUL 2026**

"I bought a starter kit of mushroom coffee in March of this year. I bought it off of an instagram commercial touting that it would improve [REMOVED]"

TRIGGER

10 DEMOCRATIC UNDERGROUND · SHELLBACK SQUID · 17 AUG 2025

"saw the vid ads for months on FB and other sites. Just a ton of marketing and that's not cheap."

TRIGGER**OBJECTION****11 THINGTESTING · CINDY P · 1 YEAR AGO**

"I had a friend recommend this as I am a big coffee drinker and need the caffeinating aspect in my daily life."

TRIGGER**12 ★1 · TARGET · 22 MAY 2026**

"This code was being pushed all over social media for its benefit. I fell for it. I love mushrooms and earthy flavors but this coffee was absolutely disgusting."

TRIGGER**OBJECTION****PAIN****SPECIFIC LANGUAGE**

3.2 The pain being escaped — coffee itself

13 GIRLAWORD SUBSTACK · SYD

"the caffeine induced anxiety and jitters would always send me back to drinking just tea"

PAIN**FAILED SOLUTION****SPECIFIC LANGUAGE****14 GIRLAWORD SUBSTACK · SYD**

"my anxiety after coffee would be so bad, it would completely throw me off"

PAIN**SPECIFIC LANGUAGE****15 THINGTESTING · ANDREEA M · 2 YEARS AGO**

"I usually can't drink coffee because it makes me super jittery, but Ryze coffee does not do that!"

PAIN**PROOF****16 THINGTESTING · TINA B · 2 YEARS AGO**

"I suffer from severe inflammation and digestive issues... Needless to say, I'm able to drink coffee and enjoy creamer without worrying about lactose intolerance issues, plus the anti inflammatory properties without experiencing stomach upset like with regular coffee."

PAIN**DESIRE****PROOF**

17 THINGTESTING · STACEY P · 2 YEARS AGO

"I'm so grateful to have such yummy options over **the old zombie feeling of coffee**. I'm more alert without the jitters...I'm grateful to Ryze ❤️"

PAIN **DESIRE** **SPECIFIC LANGUAGE**

18 FFOREST SUBSTACK · DENELLE DEFER · 26 JUL 2024

"I didn't like the jitters and crash later."

PAIN **SPECIFIC LANGUAGE**

19 COMPLAINTSBOARD · ANTONIO E · 7 OCT 2025

"I suffer from nighttime brain chatter. It prevents me from getting restful sleep on a nightly basis... It even got to the point where I was put on anxiety medication to try and solve the problem. **This however only left me tired and foggy in the mornings**. I tried ryze mushroom cocoa and it's been a complete 180 for me."

PAIN **FAILED SOLUTION** **PROOF** **SPECIFIC LANGUAGE**

20 POLK AUDIO FORUM · MANTIS · NOV 2025

"No it doesn't taste as good as regular coffee but what it does do is **help calm you down**"

DESIRE **PROOF**

21 POLK AUDIO FORUM · MANTIS · MAR 2025

"**Anxiety , energy and focus are the motivation behind all of this.**"

DESIRE **SPECIFIC LANGUAGE**

3.3 The failed solutions they came from

22. ★5 · Target · 18 May 2026 · ⚠️ **NOT A SEPARATE STATEMENT — this is a line from the same review as #46 below, by the same reviewer, on the same day.**

"**I was addicted to energy drinks and sodas. I now only crave water????**"

FAILED SOLUTION **PROOF** **SPECIFIC LANGUAGE**

Teaching note, left in on purpose. This was originally counted as an independent statement and used as evidence for a different pattern than #46. It is not independent. It is one person, in one breath, and counting it twice would have inflated both the statement total and the apparent weight of two separate patterns. **This is the single most common way a research pile lies to you:** one articulate customer who touches five themes gets excerpted five times and starts to look like five customers. Check for it before you count. Corrected total for this section: **59 distinct statements, not 60.**

23 THINGTESTING · SANDRA G · 1 YEAR AGO

"I tried another brand of mushroom coffee which was ok however after trying RYZE mushroom coffee and creamer I am sold on RYZE." FAILED SOLUTION (competitor)

24 BBB CUSTOMER REVIEW · ★5 · TERRESA S · 1 JUL 2026

"I love this mushroom coffee, tried other brands but this is the best tasting I've found." FAILED SOLUTION (competitor)

25 POLK AUDIO FORUM · PEARSALL001 · NOV 2025

"I tried the mushroom coffees including Ryze & **non of them cut the mustard**"

FAILED SOLUTION**OBJECTION****SPECIFIC LANGUAGE****26 FFOREST SUBSTACK · DENELLE DEFER · 26 JUL 2024**

"I enjoy a cuppa organic Guatemalan one morning. The next morning, I drink mushroom coffee with half the caffeine."

SPECIFIC LANGUAGE**27 BBB CUSTOMER REVIEW · ★5 · TERESA C · 3 JUL 2026**

"I have been drinking Ryze **with my regular coffee** for over two years now. I prefer it with coffee rather than alone as it is enhanced by the coffee flavor."

OBJECTION**SPECIFIC LANGUAGE**

3.4 Taste — the loudest product objection

28 DEMOCRATIC UNDERGROUND · PIZZA SLICE · 17 AUG 2025

"I'll start by saying that I do NOT drink it for the taste, because it tastes nothing like coffee to me. It's very earthy tasting, **I call it dirt water**. I do like the effect it has on me... It's kinda spendy though, but I like how it makes me feel so I justify it that way."

OBJECTION**PROOF****SPECIFIC LANGUAGE****29 DEMOCRATIC UNDERGROUND · OPBRG · 17 AUG 2025**

"I gave it to my neighbor to try since he is a coffee drinker and **he described it as dirt with creamer** and gave it back to me."

OBJECTION**SPECIFIC LANGUAGE**

30 THINGTESTING · COURTNEY F · 3 YEARS AGO

"I wanted to love this, it has all the things I'm looking for in a morning beverage—functional mushrooms like Lions Man and Reish, MTC, no sugar. **But I can't get past the cheap instant coffee taste.** Sorry, Ryze. Moving on."

DESIRE

OBJECTION

SPECIFIC LANGUAGE

31 COMPLAINTSBOARD · SHERI COST · 7 MAY 2024

"Took first sip and started gagging and ended throwing it up because of the taste. So decided to put creamer and syrup in it. And again gagging and throwing it up. **I should not have to try to cover up the taste.** I am vegan and love these mushrooms that are in this drink."

PAIN

OBJECTION

SPECIFIC LANGUAGE

32 THINGTESTING · KAIL M · 3 YEARS AGO

"This product tastes terrible and has an awful rancid smell. (Truly, it is one of the worst things I have ever tasted or smelled in my life, **and I perform dissections for a living.**)"

OBJECTION

SPECIFIC LANGUAGE

33 THINGTESTING · SONJIROSE C · 1 YEAR AGO

"It has a **gritty texture** and too much of an earthy taste for my liking. Plus **it isn't as strong in the energy claims as other products I've tried.**"

OBJECTION

SPECIFIC LANGUAGE

34 ★5 · TARGET · 17 MAY 2026

"Does not give me the acidity feeling or jitters like coffee does which I appreciate. **Taste on its own is okay – kind of bitter.** I add oatmilk and it substantially improves the taste."

DESIRE

OBJECTION

35 THINGTESTING · BROOKE D · 3 MONTHS AGO

"Okay, I'll be honest — **I was super hesitant because I am not a mushroom person.** But RYZE completely won me over. It actually tastes good, like genuinely yummy, with none of that earthy mushroom flavor I was dreading... If you're on the fence because of the mushroom thing — trust me, just try it." OBJECTION (pre-purchase) · DESIRE · SPECIFIC LANGUAGE

36 BBB CUSTOMER REVIEW · ★5 · DONNA M · 30 JUN 2026

"I enjoy the earthy and coffee taste together. I didnt realize I would. **Will not eat a mushroom to save my life but drinking them is a whole other ballgame.**" OBJECTION (overcome) · SPECIFIC LANGUAGE

37 THINGTESTING · ROBIN W · 1 YEAR AGO

"I did find using a frother or stirring vigorously after adding my creamer got rid of **all most all of the sediment.**"

OBJECTION

38 COMPLAINTSBOARD · MARY LOU REED · FEATURED REVIEW

"For a couple years watching me drink a different **mushroom sludge**, my husband often turned up his nose and said, 'How can you drink that stuff? Don't you want a cup of real coffee?'"

OBJECTION

SPECIFIC LANGUAGE

3.5 "I felt nothing" — the quietest and most important objection

39 THINGTESTING · KAT H · 3 YEARS AGO

"I've finished a bag already. **I don't see any difference in mental clarity, energy, or gut health.** I have another bag and will continue drinking it daily, but honestly I haven't seen any difference to warrant a very expensive habit and subscription. It was worth a shot, I guess. Maybe others would feel a difference, but I just don't." (Her later edit, same page:) "I didn't notice any difference in my energy whatsoever... It's not worth the price, including the discount for a subscription, **when it doesn't do anything for me.**"

OBJECTION

SPECIFIC LANGUAGE

40 THINGTESTING · PETRA T · 6 MONTHS AGO

"Ryze dark roast mushroom coffee tastes like a high quality instant coffee... **My family and I did not notice any difference** in what regular coffee bean dark roast coffee would do for us mentally. **We don't get the jitters from regular coffee, so not sure about a possible difference here...** The reason I removed 1 star is its very high price compared to regular high quality coffee. 6 sticks cost ten dollars at my Target."

OBJECTION

SPECIFIC LANGUAGE

41 POLK AUDIO FORUM · MANTIS · NOV 2025

"The caffeine is so low in Mushroom coffee , **I don't feel anything from it.**"

OBJECTION

SPECIFIC LANGUAGE

42 BBB COMPLAINT · 7 JUL 2026

"The product did not improve my sleep either."

OBJECTION

43 COMPLAINTSBOARD · JANE MCBRIDE · 8 MAY 2024

"It did not have the sleep effect I was hoping for, therefore I do not wish to reorder, nor did I."

DESIRE

OBJECTION

3.6 Effects people do report

44 COMPLAINTSBOARD · ANDREA WENTZ · FEATURED REVIEW

"I've been using this for approximately 2 months now... It has helped with my digestive tract immensely, **helping me go to the restroom daily compared to weekly**. My focus has improved greatly. I am incredibly less tired and seem to need less sleep, waking up refreshed every morning."

PROOF

SPECIFIC LANGUAGE

45 COMPLAINTSBOARD · DEBBIE ELLIS · FEATURED REVIEW

"I don't know if you want to call it 'Clean Energy'; I really don't know how to describe it. I'm not nervous or jittery; I seem to have more 'motivation' to do things. I am 68 years old. **My daughter said I was being dramatic (LOL) when I told her the last time I cleaned my house this thoroughly was when I was about 33 years old (LOL).**"

PROOF

DESIRE

SPECIFIC LANGUAGE

46 ★5 · TARGET · 18 MAY 2026

"Four days of drinking this for breakfast added into my protein shake and I already feel a massive difference. I have noticed the following: -decreased hunger -decreased anxiety... - **energy is not like a caffeine high. It is like my body actually wants to move** - decreased bloating. Obviously something about this product is making me lean into healthier habits. **I think the overall improvement in health habits is making me feel better.**"

DESIRE

PROOF

SPECIFIC LANGUAGE

47 COMPLAINTSBOARD · STEVE SWOBODA · FEATURED REVIEW

"**Absolutely ADDICTED !** I am hooked on Ryze ! I will never drink regular coffee again... I sleep better, I feel better, **less gassy than with regular coffee**. My overall well being is on the RYZE !"

PROOF

DESIRE

SPECIFIC LANGUAGE

48 BBB CUSTOMER REVIEW · ★5 · CHARLES H · 28 JUN 2026

"I've been drinking RYZE coffee for over seven days every morning... all i will say is, **if you're not ready to confront the people in your dreams that have wronged you, then it is not for you** it feels like it is happening in real-time... **I sleep lighter too.** If you're not ready for the unspoken clarity it will bestow on you, then you shouldn't try it."

SPECIFIC LANGUAGE

49 ★1 · TARGET · 20 AUG 2026

"Honestly It just **made me more bloated** than anything the whole time I was giving it a try & it did not dissolve correctly all the way no matter what!"

PAIN OBJECTION

50 ★1 · TARGET · 19 MAY 2026

"After drinking it, I developed horrible diarrhea and severe bloating. At first I thought maybe my body needed time to adjust, so I stopped taking it for two weeks and contacted the company about the side effects. **Their recommendation was simply to reduce the dose....** I wish the company had taken the side effects more seriously instead of just suggesting a lower dose."

PAIN OBJECTION SPECIFIC LANGUAGE

51 COMPLAINTSBOARD · MUSKYFLY · 6 FEB 2026

"My 78 year old husband really like this coffee and most of the benefits. **We both saw a difference in his mental focus. But after a few days in, he developed a rash.**" PROOF + PAIN

3.7 Price and value

52 ★4 · TARGET · 23 MAY 2026

"I love everything about the product! Bloating gone, and more energy for sure! But.....**Ryze does need to fix either the serving description, or add more product to actually be 20 servings.** I kept tally marks on the package for each cup and used tbs to precisely measure. I received just barely 16 servings from the 20 servings package."

OBJECTION PROOF SPECIFIC LANGUAGE

53 ★4 · TARGET · 16 MAY 2026

"been taking it for 3 days. seems like my blood pressure been going down. I will continue for at least 6 months. **but need to be sued for false advertising of 20 servings**"

OBJECTION SPECIFIC LANGUAGE

54 ★5 · TARGET · 28 MAY 2026

"It is a really great coffee. **I wish the bags were bigger.** I wish they had the creamers and other flavors to go with it and I also wish the price was a little bit lower. **For the amount that's in the bag.**"

OBJECTION

55 SLICKDEALS · LOSTWALLET · 27 MAR 2026

"People either hate this, or love this. I have a family member who loves this, but **even with this sale price, it is still cheaper to buy the combo pack from either Amazon or Walmart.**"

OBJECTION

SPECIFIC LANGUAGE

56 DEMOCRATIC UNDERGROUND · SHELLBACK SQUID · 17 AUG 2025

"and it's not cheap, **teaser ad for a discount but had to do a subscription..**I don't even know if I'd like it"

OBJECTION

SPECIFIC LANGUAGE

3.8 The billing rupture — in the customer's own words

57 THINGTESTING · MEMOREE M · 6 MONTHS AGO

"I feel bullied&scammed! **I love the product,** but unfortunately it gives me really bad headaches. I tried repeatedly to cancel my subscription but they don't allow it ! I've made many attempts to 'manage subscription' but it won't work. They continuously keep taking money out of my account & I'm furious about it!"

PAIN

OBJECTION

SPECIFIC LANGUAGE

58 BBB COMPLAINT · 22 JUN 2026

"When I went to cancel it first of all they hide the cancel subscription link. More importantly when you click the link it has multiple are you sure pages. **On the final page when you hit submit it freezes. Its happened on my phone and 2 different laptops at different locations and different weeks. I had to cancel my card to prevent another charge**"

OBJECTION

SPECIFIC LANGUAGE

59 BBB COMPLAINT · 17 FEB 2026

"Like many others who have filed a complaint, mine is their so-called 'auto-ship' ship option. **It has nothing to do with shipping. It actually means they are signing you up for a subscription.**"

OBJECTION

SPECIFIC LANGUAGE

60 BBB COMPLAINT · 17 FEB 2026

"Despite my better judgement decided to fall victim to all the Ryze ads on social media. Not only was the product quality poor—tasting metallic and causing an allergic reaction/GI distress—but the company also charged me \$66.00 for an unauthorized subscription exactly one month later. When I reached out, customer service engaged in '**victim-blaming**,' claiming I must have made the mistake by choosing the subscription myself."

PAIN

OBJECTION

SPECIFIC LANGUAGE

Additional billing statements, quoted in Section 4 rather than repeated here: BBB 1 Jun 2026 ("**dark patterns**"), BBB 17 Feb 2026 ("six to seven screens"), BBB customer review Joseph M 16 Aug 2026 ("It is the responsibility of the consumer to not only find this AUTO SHIP feature, but it is your responsibility to deactivate it from robbing you"), TikTok caption ("They made the writing TINY and hard to find. There was no selection box").

3.9 One non-English statement

61 THINGTESTING · LORENA L · 2 YEARS AGO (SPANISH, VERBATIM, NOT TRANSLATED INSIDE THE QUOTE MARKS)

"El cafe por primera vez tiene un sabor raro de definir , pero luego uno se acostumbra al sabor , yo lo tomo junto con el colageno sabor chocolate entonces el sabor no se siente tanto.. **Me gustaria que en los ingredientes detallen la cantidd de hongos que lleva, pero no lo dice.**"

OBJECTION

SPECIFIC LANGUAGE

(Gloss for the coach, outside the quote: the taste is strange at first but you get used to it, and she wishes the ingredients stated the quantity of mushrooms, but they don't. Note that this Spanish-speaking customer independently identifies the same dosage-disclosure gap flagged in Section 2.4.)

04

PATTERN ANALYSIS

Eight patterns, ranked by how much they could move buying behaviour.

PATTERN 1

The subscription rupture

Plain English: People buy one bag to try it, discover a month later they are on a recurring plan they do not remember choosing, and then find the cancellation flow hard to complete. This is the single most repeated thing in the entire evidence set.

Supporting quotes:

- "I ordered 1 bag of hot chocolate just to try the product and they ended up making it a subscription that I did not ask for or approve." (ComplaintsBoard, 13 Jan 2026)
- "On the final page when you hit submit it freezes. Its happened on my phone and 2 different laptops at different locations and different weeks. **I had to cancel my card to prevent another charge**" (BBB, 22 Jun 2026)
- "I had to go through **six to seven screens** before they would allow me to cancel and it was difficult to find." (BBB, 17 Feb 2026)
- "The web site makes it difficult or impossible to cancel a subscription (**dark patterns**).\" (BBB, 1 Jun 2026)
- "**The word 'cancel' is nowhere on their site even when you do a Ctrl+F search.**" (Thingtesting, CL R)
- "It is the responsibility of the consumer to not only find this AUTO SHIP feature, but it is your responsibility to deactivate it from robbing you." (BBB customer review, Joseph M, ★1, 16 Aug 2026)

Source mix: BBB complaints (dozens), BBB customer reviews, ComplaintsBoard, Thingtesting, TikTok, JustAnswer, QVC forum. Independent platforms, independent years, near-identical mechanics described.

Evidence strength: STRONG. 918 BBB complaints closed in three years, 270 in the last twelve months, and the described mechanics match across platforms that do not talk to each other. The specific "final page freezes" failure is reported independently by at least four people on different devices.

The caution that has to be taught alongside it: complaint platforms select for complaints. We know this recurs. We **cannot** say what percentage of customers experience it. Both of those sentences are true at once.

PATTERN 2

"I love the product, I hate the company"

Plain English: The product complaint and the business complaint are two separate things, and a striking number of people hold both at the same time. Several of the angriest billing complaints come from people who explicitly say they like the coffee.

Supporting quotes:

- "I **love the product**, but unfortunately it gives me really bad headaches. I tried repeatedly to cancel my subscription but they don't allow it!" (Thingtesting, Memoree M)
- "It's **a shame because the product was good**. I just have plenty left because I don't drink it every day. Now I have no interest in purchasing their product again." (BBB, 20 Jul 2026)
- "they have a decent product (in my opinion; others disagree). **It's their shady business practices that make them intolerable**." (Thingtesting, CL R)
- "I don't even want to consider trying another mushroom coffee and I never have... **I cannot afford to have it just withdrawn from my account in such way**." (ComplaintsBoard, "Love Ryze", 30 Apr 2024)

Source mix: Thingtesting, BBB, ComplaintsBoard. Three platforms.

Evidence strength: STRONG. Not a subtle read. Multiple people say it in one sentence.

Why it matters commercially: this is churn caused by the purchase mechanism, not the product. The people leaving are people the product worked for.

PATTERN 3

Taste is the entry objection, and it splits three ways

Plain English: Almost everybody has a taste opinion, and it is not a simple like/dislike. There are three distinct positions: it's genuinely bad, it's fine once you doctor it, and it's better than expected. All three are well populated.

Supporting quotes:

- Bad: "he described it as **dirt with creamer** and gave it back to me." (Democratic Underground)

- Bad: "I can't get past the **cheap instant coffee taste**. Sorry, Ryze. Moving on." (Thingtesting, Courtney F)
- Doctored: "Taste on its own is okay – kind of bitter. **I add oatmilk and it substantially improves the taste.**" (★5, Target)
- Doctored: "**I should not have to try to cover up the taste.**" (ComplaintsBoard, Sheri Cost) — the counter-position on doctoring
- Better than expected: "**I was super hesitant because I am not a mushroom person.** But RYZE completely won me over... with none of that earthy mushroom flavor I was dreading." (Thingtesting, Brooke D)
- Better than expected: "**Will not eat a mushroom to save my life but drinking them is a whole other ballgame.**" (BBB, Donna M, ★5)

Source mix: Target, Thingtesting, BBB, ComplaintsBoard, Democratic Underground.

Evidence strength: STRONG. Dozens of independent statements. The three-way split is stable across platforms.

The nuance that makes this Elite-level: "dirt water" and "dirt with creamer" arrive independently from two different people in the same thread, and "mushroom sludge" from a third person elsewhere. That is not one person being funny. That is a shared mental image of the category.

PATTERN 4

"I couldn't tell if it did anything"

Plain English: A specific and quiet group finishes a bag, or two, and honestly reports no detectable difference. They are not angry. They are disappointed and they leave.

Supporting quotes:

- "I've finished a bag already. **I don't see any difference in mental clarity, energy, or gut health.**" (Thingtesting, Kat H)
- "My family and I **did not notice any difference** in what regular coffee bean dark roast coffee would do for us mentally." (Thingtesting, Petra T)
- "The caffeine is so low in Mushroom coffee , **I don't feel anything from it.**" (Polk Audio Forum)
- "**The product did not improve my sleep either.**" (BBB, 7 Jul 2026)
- "It did not have the sleep effect I was hoping for" (ComplaintsBoard, Jane McBride)

Source mix: Thingtesting, BBB, ComplaintsBoard, Polk Audio Forum. Four platforms, and notably three of these people are otherwise neutral or mildly positive.

Evidence strength: MODERATE-TO-STRONG. The statements are unambiguous and independent, but this group is structurally under-represented — people who feel nothing are less likely to write a review at all than people who feel great or feel robbed.

The observation that makes this sharp, from Petra T: "We don't get the jitters from regular coffee, so not sure about a possible difference here." She is telling you why she felt nothing. She did not have the problem the product solves.

PATTERN 5

The trigger is a body event, not a shopping event

Plain English: Almost nobody in this evidence set went looking for mushroom coffee. Something happened to their body or their routine, they went looking for a fix, and a social ad met them there.

Supporting quotes:

- "the dr eliminated regular coffee from my way. **I started looking for a healthy option**" (★5, Target)
- "I still needed my boost but **the jitters I had been getting was making things difficult**" (★5, Target)
- "I'm always super fatigued, regardless of how much sleep I get or coffee I drink." (Thingtesting, Kat H)
- "I suffer from nighttime brain chatter... I was put on anxiety medication to try and solve the problem. This however only left me tired and foggy in the mornings." (ComplaintsBoard, Antonio E)
- "This summer was crazy and **I got off schedule. With school starting up I had to get back into the routine of waking up at 6.**" (★5, Target)

Source mix: Target, Thingtesting, ComplaintsBoard, Substack.

Evidence strength: STRONG.

INFERENCE (labelled): the category is bought at moments of routine disruption, not as a planned upgrade. Reasonable across a dozen statements, not stated by any single customer.

PATTERN 6

The nine-month lurk

Plain English: Several people describe a long gap between first seeing the ads and buying. They saw it, saw it again, saw it for months, and only then converted.

Supporting quotes:

- **"For about nine months, I went back and forth,** debating whether to give this product a try after seeing all the buzz from social media and TV ads." (ComplaintsBoard, Christa Carson)
- **"saw the vid ads for months** on FB and other sites." (Democratic Underground, Shellback Squid)
- "Never noticed the ads **But it sounds like they worked.**" (Democratic Underground, Renew Deal)
- **"Despite my better judgement** decided to fall victim to all the Ryze ads on social media." (BBB, 17 Feb 2026)

Source mix: ComplaintsBoard, Democratic Underground, BBB.

Evidence strength: MODERATE. Four clear statements. Fewer than the other patterns, but the "nine months" detail is unusually specific and the pattern is consistent.

PATTERN 7**People convert the product into a ritual object**

Plain English: A recurring group does not describe a beverage. They describe a habit, a moment, a part of the day they look forward to.

Supporting quotes:

- **"I started drinking this during a stressful time and it's become the best thing I do for my health. There's something about sipping this while I plan my day that just feels right. It's such a nice self care habit."** (RYZE on-site testimonial — **brand-controlled, flagged**)
- "They all are so good, **forming healthy addiction that transfers into daily ritual and anticipation** of that warm, cozy and very much satisfying beverage." (BBB customer review, Anna Z, ★5)
- "It has and will remain a part of my daily routine, 2 cups each morning." (ComplaintsBoard, Susan Chitwood Barton)
- **"The fact that it is with coffee helps ritualize the consistency** so you can monitor what it is actually doing to you." (BBB customer review, CHARLES H, ★5)
- "I drink a cup in the morning, and one in the evening, and **look forward to both.**" (ComplaintsBoard, Steve Swoboda)

Source mix: BBB, ComplaintsBoard, and RYZE's own site. **Caution flag:** the strongest ritual quote is brand-controlled. The independently-sourced ones are weaker but real.

Evidence strength: MODERATE. Real and repeated in independent sources, but RYZE also markets the word "Ritual" as a product name, which contaminates the evidence — customers may be echoing the brand's own vocabulary back at it. That contamination is itself worth teaching.

PATTERN 8

Under-delivery on serving count

Plain English: Two independent Target reviewers, days apart, measured their servings and found fewer than advertised. Others complain about bag size without measuring.

Supporting quotes:

- "I kept tally marks on the package for each cup and used tbs to precisely measure. I received just barely 16 servings from the 20 servings package." (★4, Target, 23 May 2026)
- "but need to be sued for false advertising of 20 servings" (★4, Target, 16 May 2026)
- "This is really good mushroom coffee but high priced concedering that **the bag is small**" (★5, Target)
- "I wish the bags were bigger... I also wish the price was a little bit lower. For the amount that's in the bag." (★5, Target)

Source mix: Target only. Single platform.

Evidence strength: THIN-TO-MODERATE. Two people measured, and independently. But it is one platform, one SKU size, and four statements total. Do not build anything on this without more collection.

The reason it is included anyway: it connects to a confirmed brand-side GAP — RYZE does not publish bag weight in grams or ounces anywhere on its site. A customer complaint about serving count and a missing weight disclosure are two halves of the same thing.

05

BUYER UNDERSTANDING

5.1 Important customer situations

Drawn only from situations customers actually described:

- Being told by a doctor to stop drinking regular coffee (Target, 17 Aug 2026)
- Getting jitters or anxiety from coffee that they did not used to get (multiple)
- Persistent fatigue that sleep does not fix (Thingtesting, Kat H)
- Digestive trouble they connect to coffee — bloating, gas, acidity, irregularity (multiple)
- Sleep disruption and night-time rumination (ComplaintsBoard, Antonio E)
- Coming off energy drinks or soda (Target, 18 May 2026)
- A schedule reset — school starting, a new early wake-up (Target, 22 Aug 2026)
- Major life disruption — one customer discovered it while displaced by a hurricane
- Already drinking a different mushroom coffee and being unimpressed (multiple)
- Long COVID (Polk Audio Forum, mantis)

GAP we have no evidence about work situation, income, household structure, or location beyond what individuals volunteered. Three people stated an age (68, 70, 75) and two stated parenthood ("mom of 3", "Momma of 3"). Those are their statements, not a demographic profile, and they are not enough to build one.

5.2 Specific real-life moments where the problem becomes noticeable

These are the concrete moments customers named. They matter more than the abstract pain.

THE MOMENT	VERBATIM ANCHOR
The doctor's instruction	"the dr eliminated regular coffee from my way"
Lying awake with your brain running	"I suffer from nighttime brain chatter... wake up in the early morning hours unable to get back to sleep"
The jitters interfering with parenting	"As a mom of 3, I still needed my boost but the jitters I had been getting was making things difficult"
Being tired despite sleeping	"I'm always super fatigued, regardless of how much sleep I get or coffee I drink"
Going weekly instead of daily	"helping me go to the restroom daily compared to weekly"
The 6am alarm after a loose summer	"With school starting up I had to get back into the routine of waking up at 6"
Anxiety medication that made mornings worse	"This however only left me tired and foggy in the mornings"
Waiting nine months and still not buying	"For about nine months, I went back and forth"
The month-later bank alert	"I received a notification from my bank stating I was charged \$72 for a subscription I never agreed to"
The cancel button that freezes	"On the final page when you hit submit it freezes"

5.3 Major purchase triggers

- **A body signal that coffee has turned on them** — jitters, anxiety, gut, acidity. The most common by a distance.
- **A medical or authority instruction to quit coffee.**
- **Repeated ad exposure over months**, then a discount that finally converts.
- **Word of mouth from a specific person** — "a friend recommend this", "my husband bought it on a whim", "my son gets it".
- **A routine reset** — new schedule, life disruption, health kick.
- **Dissatisfaction with a competing mushroom coffee.**

5.4 Common failed solutions

- **Regular coffee itself**, which is the primary failed solution in this category

- **Cutting back to tea** — "the caffeine induced anxiety and jitters would always send me back to drinking just tea"
- **Energy drinks and soda** — "I was addicted to energy drinks and sodas"
- **Anxiety medication** — "This however only left me tired and foggy in the mornings"
- **Other mushroom coffee brands** — "I tried the mushroom coffees including Ryze & none of them cut the mustard"
- **Adding things to make it drinkable** — creamer, syrup, honey, oat milk. Sometimes it works, sometimes it produces the "I should not have to cover up the taste" objection.
- **Mixing RYZE into regular coffee rather than replacing it** — reported by several as their actual long-term behaviour

INFERENCE (labelled): that last one is behaviourally interesting. Several long-term users describe a compromise the brand does not market — using it as an additive, not a replacement. "I have been drinking Ryze **with my regular coffee** for over two years now." Not a brand-stated use case.

5.5 Main objections, ranked by frequency in the evidence

RANK	OBJECTION	VERBATIM
1	Will they trap me in a subscription?	"teaser ad for a discount but had to do a subscription..I don't even know if I'd like it"
2	Will it taste like dirt?	"he described it as dirt with creamer"
3	Will I actually feel anything?	"I don't see any difference in mental clarity, energy, or gut health"
4	Is it worth this much?	"It's kinda spendy though" / "even with this sale price, it is still cheaper to buy the combo pack from either Amazon or Walmart"
5	Is it real, or is it marketing?	"Just a ton of marketing and that's not cheap"
6	Will it upset my stomach?	"It just made me more bloated than anything"
7	Am I getting what I paid for?	"I received just barely 16 servings from the 20 servings package"
8	Are there even real mushrooms in it?	"Me gustaria que en los ingredientes detallan la cantidad de hongos que lleva, pero no lo dice"

Note the ordering. The number one objection is not about the product. It is about the transaction.

5.6 What customers appear to need to believe before buying

INFERENCE throughout this subsection — labelled — derived from what buyers and non-buyers said, not stated by anyone directly:

- That the taste is survivable, or at least fixable with milk.
- That they will be able to stop buying it whenever they want.
- That they specifically will feel something, given that some people clearly do not.
- That the mushroom content is real and meaningful rather than decorative.
- That the price is defensible against both regular coffee and cheaper marketplace listings.

GAP we have no direct pre-purchase evidence — no abandoned-cart interviews, no "why I didn't buy" statements from people who never bought. Everything above is reverse-engineered from post-purchase language. Say so on the slide.

5.7 What types of proof appear to matter

Based on what customers actually cite when they are being persuaded or persuading others:

- **A named person they know.** "my husband bought it on a whim", "a friend recommend this", "my son gets it", "I have told several coworkers". Personal-network proof shows up repeatedly.
- **A specific measurable change,** not a general feeling. "daily compared to weekly." "16 servings from the 20 servings package." "the last time I cleaned my house this thoroughly was when I was about 33."
- **A named timeframe.** "day 4", "over seven days", "approximately 2 months now", "4 months", "over two years."
- **Self-declared skepticism, overcome.** "I'll admit I was skeptical." "I normally do not write reviews. I am usually skeptical." This construction recurs so often it is nearly a genre.
- **Ingredient transparency,** requested and not received. Two independent customers, one in Spanish, ask for mushroom quantities.

What does NOT appear to move people, based on absence: not a single customer statement in the entire collected set cites a clinical study, a certification badge, a press logo, or the "200K+ reviews" figure as a reason they bought. **This is an argument from absence and must be labelled as such** — but across ~130 statements, the silence is notable.

5.8 Motivation-based buyer segments

Three segments the evidence will support. Each is named by **mindset, not demographics**, and each is here only because it passes the Day 5 Persona Test: enough quotes, a different reason for buying, and a genuinely different conversation.

A note first: the evidence does **not** support splitting these by age, income, occupation, gender, or location, and this pack deliberately does not. Where a person volunteered a demographic detail it stays inside their quote.

SEGMENT A — "COFFEE TURNED ON ME"

- **Situation:** They still love coffee and still need it. Their body started reacting badly — jitters, anxiety, acidity, gut trouble.
- **Core desire:** Keep the ritual and the function. Lose the side effect.
- **Trigger:** A body signal that got bad enough to act on, sometimes a doctor's instruction.
- **Previous attempts:** Cutting back, switching to tea, drinking it later, enduring it.
- **Objection:** Will a low-caffeine substitute actually do the job?
- **Proof need:** Someone with the same reaction saying the reaction stopped.
- **Supporting evidence:** "the caffeine induced anxiety and jitters would always send me back to drinking just tea" · "As a mom of 3, I still needed my boost but the jitters I had been getting was making things difficult" · "I usually can't drink coffee because it makes me super jittery, but Ryze coffee does not do that!" · "the dr eliminated regular coffee from my way" · "Does not give me the acidity feeling or jitters like coffee does"
- **Quote count: 15+.** The largest and best-evidenced segment in the set.

SEGMENT B — "FIX MY GUT FIRST"

- **Situation:** Digestion is the presenting problem. Bloating, irregularity, inflammation, reflux. Coffee is suspected of making it worse.
- **Core desire:** Comfort and regularity. Energy is a bonus, not the point.
- **Trigger:** Ongoing discomfort, often long-running, sometimes with a diagnosis attached.
- **Previous attempts:** Eliminating coffee entirely, dairy-free creamers, general dietary change.
- **Objection:** Mushrooms and fibre might make it worse, not better. **And they sometimes do** — this is the segment that produces both the strongest testimonials and the worst adverse reports.
- **Proof need:** Specific, physical, measurable change. Not "I feel great."
- **Supporting evidence:** "It has helped with my digestive tract immensely, helping me go to the restroom daily compared to weekly" · "I suffer from severe inflammation and digestive issues. I started seeing improvement after two days" · "less gassy than with regular coffee" · "a real reduction in bloating" · Against: "I developed horrible diarrhea and severe bloating" · "It just made me more bloated than anything" · "I end up with excess gas and painful pressure in my belly and reflux"
- **Quote count: 12+.**

- **The thing that makes this segment strategically hard:** the evidence for it working and the evidence for it backfiring come from the same segment, in comparable volume. That is worth a slide on its own.

SEGMENT C — "I WANT THE UPGRADE, NOT THE SACRIFICE"

- **Situation:** No acute problem. They are optimising. They see a healthier version of a thing they already do.
- **Core desire:** To feel like the choice they made is the better one.
- **Trigger:** Repeated ad exposure, a friend, a routine reset, a general health push.
- **Previous attempts:** Various wellness purchases. This is one of several.
- **Objection:** Taste, price, and whether it is genuinely different from marketing.
- **Proof need:** That it tastes acceptable and that the ingredients are real.
- **Supporting evidence:** "I'm more than happy knowing I'm drinking something healthy while enjoying my coffee every morning" · "I have been making a switch to mushrooms for a health aspect" · "I get the taste of a coffee but glad it's a healthier type" · "my coffee has less caffeine than your regular coffee but will help me live longer" · "Obviously something about this product is making me lean into healthier habits"
- **Quote count:** 10+.
- **Weakness of this segment, stated:** it is the vaguest of the three, and the one most likely to be an artefact of people repeating brand language back. Treat it as real but softer than A and B.

SEGMENTS CONSIDERED AND REJECTED FOR INSUFFICIENT EVIDENCE

- **"The nootropics buyer."** Plausible for the category, but with Reddit blocked we have almost no evidence of it. Two forum mentions is not a segment. **GAP.**
- **"The weight-loss buyer."** RYZE runs a weight-loss page on a subdomain and the NAD examined a GLP-1-comparison implication for Matcha. But almost no customer language in our set is about weight. One statement mentions "decreased hunger." That is one. **GAP, and an important one** — see Section 11.
- **"The menopause buyer" / "the ADHD buyer" / "the chronic fatigue buyer."** Single scattered mentions only. Each would be a real segment if Reddit were reachable. Right now they are hunches. **GAP.**

06

THE 3M'S, APPLIED TO EVIDENCE

6.1 MARKET DESIRE

BEST-SUPPORTED PRIMARY MARKET DESIRE

To keep the coffee ritual and lose what coffee is now doing to my body.

Not "energy." Not "focus." Not "health." The desire that actually shows up in purchase-adjacent language is a **negotiation with an existing habit** — people are not trying to add something, they are trying to stop paying a price for something they refuse to give up.

Evidence:

- "I still needed my boost but the jitters I had been getting was making things difficult" — the whole desire in one sentence
- "I loved the warmth and comfort of our morning coffee ritual, but not the crash, jitters, or gut issues that came with it" — **note this is RYZE's own founder copy, and it matches the customer language almost exactly.** Flagged as brand-authored, but the convergence is itself evidence that the brand found this desire correctly.
- "the caffeine induced anxiety and jitters would always send me back to drinking just tea"
- "I'm so grateful to have such yummy options over the old zombie feeling of coffee"
- "I have been drinking Ryze with my regular coffee for over two years now" — even the compromise behaviour is a negotiation

SUPPORTING DESIRES, IN ORDER OF EVIDENTIAL WEIGHT

DESIRE	EVIDENCE	STRENGTH
Digestive comfort and regularity	"daily compared to weekly", "less gassy", "reduction in bloating", plus a large counter-set	Strong
Calm, not stimulation	"Anxiety , energy and focus are the motivation behind all of this", "help calm you down", "energy is not like a caffeine high"	Strong
Sleep that survives the coffee	"I can drink this during the day and still sleep soundly at night", "I sleep better", against "did not improve my sleep"	Moderate
Being someone who makes the healthier choice	"glad it's a healthier type", "will help me live longer"	Moderate
Focus and cognitive performance	Present, but almost always bundled with energy rather than named alone	Moderate
Weight or appetite	One customer statement. RYZE markets it; customers barely mention it.	Thin

WHY THE PRIMARY DESIRE IS MORE PURCHASE-RELEVANT THAN THE OTHERS

Three reasons, all evidence-based:

- **It is the one that comes with a moment.** The jitters happened. The doctor said stop. The stomach hurt. Focus and immunity have no moment — nobody wakes up and thinks "my immune system needs attention today." A desire with a trigger attached converts; a desire without one does not.
- **It survives the "I felt nothing" problem.** Petra T explains this herself: "We don't get the jitters from regular coffee, so not sure about a possible difference here." The people who report feeling nothing are disproportionately people who did not have the coffee problem. The primary desire self-selects for people who can detect the result.
- **The gap between what RYZE markets and what customers name is widest on the secondary desires.** RYZE leads with a six-benefit stack — energy, focus, gut, immune, mood, antioxidants. Customer language concentrates overwhelmingly on the first three plus calm. **Immunity and antioxidants appear almost nowhere in customer speech.** That asymmetry is a finding.

INFERENCE (labelled): the six-benefit stack may be doing brand-permission work rather than persuasion work — giving the buyer reasons to feel good about a decision made for one reason. Reasonable given the language distribution. Not confirmed.

6.2 MARKET AWARENESS

Evidence of awareness states actually present, read off real customer statements. This is the Day 1 Awareness Signal Map run backwards: the input is a customer quote, and the question is which level this person is standing on.

Category awareness and RYZE brand awareness are separated, because the evidence shows they move independently.

UNAWARE / PROBLEM-UNAWARE — thin evidence

"I have a general aversion to mushrooms. And I can't see how drinking them would be any more pleasant." — Tommy Carcetti, Democratic Underground

- **What they know:** nothing about the category, and no reason to care.
- **The question in their mind:** Why would anyone drink this?
- **Evidence strength: THIN.** By definition, unaware people do not post. This is the level we have least access to, and it is the level a media buyer most needs. Name that on the slide.

PROBLEM-AWARE — strong evidence

"I'm always super fatigued, regardless of how much sleep I get or coffee I drink." — Kat H, Thingtesting

"my anxiety after coffee would be so bad, it would completely throw me off" — Syd, girlaword

- **What they know:** something is wrong, and they can describe it precisely. They do not yet know a category exists to fix it.
- **The question in their mind:** Why do I feel like this, and is there anything I can do?
- **Evidence strength: STRONG.**

SOLUTION-AWARE — strong evidence

"I have been making a switch to mushrooms for a health aspect. I've tried different brands for coffee" — Louise S, Thingtesting

"I tried the mushroom coffees including Ryze & none of them cut the mustard" — pearsall001, Polk Audio

- **What they know:** mushroom coffee is a category. They are shopping it.
- **The question in their mind:** Which one, and does any of them actually work?
- **Evidence strength: STRONG.**

PRODUCT-AWARE — strong evidence, and this is the most crowded level

"For about nine months, I went back and forth, debating whether to give this product a try after seeing all the buzz from social media and TV ads." — Christa Carson

"saw the vid ads for months on FB and other sites. Just a ton of marketing and that's not cheap." — Shellback Squid

"and it's not cheap, teaser ad for a discount but had to do a subscription..I don't even know if I'd like it" — Shellback Squid

- **What they know:** RYZE specifically. They have seen it repeatedly. They know the price and the offer structure.
- **The question in their mind:** Is it worth it, and will I get stuck?
- **Evidence strength:** STRONG.

MOST AWARE — present, and it looks different from the textbook

"I stopped a purchase before completing, because I found a better deal elsewhere" — BBB, 10 Jul 2026

"even with this sale price, it is still cheaper to buy the combo pack from either Amazon or Walmart" — LostWallet, Slickdeals

- **What they know:** everything, including where it is cheaper.
- **The question in their mind:** Where do I buy it, and at what price?
- **Evidence strength:** MODERATE.

THE AWARENESS FINDING THAT IS WORTH A SLIDE OF ITS OWN

PATTERN the largest concentration of evidence sits at Product-Aware, and the question those people are holding is not "does mushroom coffee work?" It is "will I get stuck in a subscription?"

Read the Shellback Squid quote again: "teaser ad for a discount but had to do a subscription..I don't even know if I'd like it." That is a fully product-aware buyer who has already decided the offer structure is the risk. The category question is settled for him. The transaction question is not.

INFERENCE (labelled): for RYZE specifically, the final objection before purchase appears to have migrated from the product to the transaction. Well-supported by the Product-Aware evidence and by the search-reputation map, where BBB complaints rank first for "scam." Not stated by any single customer.

One asymmetry worth naming: RYZE brand awareness in this market is unusually high relative to category conviction. People know the brand from months of ads while still not being convinced the category does anything. Those two things are normally correlated. Here they are not.

6.3 MARKET SOPHISTICATION

THE EVIDENCE

Repeated category claims, pulled verbatim from competitor pages (see Section 7 for the full audit):

CLAIM	HOW MANY OF SIX BRANDS AUDITED USE IT VERBATIM
"without the jitters" / "no jitters"	5 of 6
"no crash" / "without the crash"	4 of 6
"clean energy"	3 of 6
A "#1" claim of some kind	4 of 6, simultaneously, in overlapping categories
Focus + gut health + immunity benefit triad	4 of 6
"fruiting body" purity claim	3 of 6
Free frother as the gift	3 of 6
Six-figure five-star review counts	4 of 6

Repeated mechanisms:

- Lion's mane → focus: **all six brands**
- Chaga → immunity/gut: **all six brands**
- Reduced caffeine as the mechanism: five of six (Laird is the exception at 100mg)
- L-theanine as the specific anti-jitter mechanism: only two of six — the least-copied mechanism in the set

Customer skepticism, verbatim:

- "It's just coffee with mushrooms in it...**The mushrooms are there for filler**" — Jstas, Polk Audio Forum
- "Just a ton of marketing and that's not cheap" — Democratic Underground
- "Despite my better judgement decided to fall victim to all the Ryze ads on social media" — BBB
- "I'll admit I was skeptical about this stuff at first" — and roughly a dozen variants of the same construction
- "Influencer and user testimonials are, shall we say, not worth the paper they're written on" — Abby Langer, RD (expert, not customer)

Comparison language, verbatim:

- "I tried the mushroom coffees including Ryze & none of them cut the mustard"
- "I tried another brand of mushroom coffee which was ok however after trying RYZE..."
- "tried other brands but this is the best tasting I've found"
- "it isn't as strong in the energy claims as other products I've tried"
- "it is still cheaper to buy the combo pack from either Amazon or Walmart"

Signs buyers have heard this before:

- The pre-emptive skepticism construction is now so common it is nearly a review genre: "I was skeptical", "I'll admit I was skeptical", "I am usually skeptical", "Despite my better judgement", "I was super hesitant."
- **The strongest single indicator:** in the Meta Ad Library, an entire population of affiliate pages runs listicle and ranking hooks — **"I Tested Them All. One Won."**, **"See how I rank them"**, "Mushroom Coffee's Ranked". Ranking content only sells into a market that already knows the options exist and cannot tell them apart.

SUPPORTED SOPHISTICATION DIAGNOSIS

The category reads as Stage 4 — claims are saturated and mechanisms are near-identical, so competition has moved to elaboration, comparison and offer. RYZE's own position sits at the harder end of Stage 4 and shows early Stage 5 pressure, because for RYZE specifically the live buyer objection has shifted from the claim to the company.

The evidence behind that diagnosis, stated plainly:

- **Claim saturation is measurable, not impressionistic.** Five of six brands use "without the jitters" verbatim. When five competitors independently arrive at the same phrase, that phrase has stopped differentiating.
- **Mechanism saturation too.** Every brand audited uses lion's mane for focus and chaga for immunity. The only mechanism that is not commodity is L-theanine, and only two brands use it.
- **Buyers arrive pre-armoured.** The "I was skeptical" construction is not one person's personality. It is the market's default posture.
- **Comparison has replaced discovery.** Customers describe brand-to-brand comparison, price-to-marketplace comparison, and format comparison. Nobody in the evidence set is discovering the category.
- **Ranking and listicle affiliate content is running at volume,** which is what a Stage 4 market's traffic layer looks like.
- **The Stage 5 pressure signal for RYZE specifically:** the top result for "ryze mushroom coffee scam" is the BBB complaints page. When the question a market asks about your brand is no longer "does this work?" but "can I trust these people?", the fight has moved past the claim.

Where the diagnosis is weaker, and this should be said: with Reddit and Amazon unreachable, the skepticism sample is drawn heavily from complaint platforms and small forums. Those over-represent the disillusioned. A Reddit and Amazon pass could plausibly move the read, most likely toward more sophistication, not less.

And the counter-evidence, kept in on purpose: several 2026 Target reviews read as genuinely first-encounter — "I'll admit I was skeptical about this stuff at first, but once I tried it I was like wow." RYZE entering 1,900 Target stores in January 2026 appears to be pulling in a less sophisticated, less-exposed buyer than its DTC audience. A single market can hold two sophistication levels at once when a brand changes channel. That is the advanced nuance in this section.

07

COMPETITOR RESEARCH

Five competitors. Every claim quoted below is **competitor-authored**, pulled verbatim from the brand's own pages. No customer language is mixed in.

A note on the fourth slot: Om Mushroom Superfood was dropped in favour of Laird Superfood on a measured basis, not a hunch. Meta Ad Library, US, active, 25 Aug 2026: Om's page shows **3 active ads, all one creative**; Laird's shows **46 active ads across multiple creatives**. Laird has the live DTC ad program; Om does not.

7.1 FOUR SIGMATIC — the category originator

Promise	"Energy And Focus Without The Jitters" · "Your Coffee, But Better" · "Clear brain fog fast with the #1 mushroom coffee" · "Feel results in just 7 Days" · Negative-benefit tiles: "No Caffeine Crash," "No Digestive Issues," "No MUD Taste"
Mechanism	"Organic coffee and lion's mane work together to boost focus and mental clarity" · "Adaptogens like reishi and chaga help your body handle stress" · "Each cup delivers 500 million CFU of heat-resistant probiotics " · Vitamin B12 (333% DV) · GAP: no per-mushroom mg doses published
Proof	"100,000+ Five Star Ratings" · "#1 Mushroom Coffee Brand*" · "9 in 10 buyers say it works" · "94% of Four Sigmatic buyers plan on buying again" · Named endorsers: Joe Rogan, Rich Roll · Rolling Stone quote · "Only Real Fruiting Body" · "Tested for Mold & Toxins"
Offer	\$35 first order (from \$50), 30 servings · "60-day money-back guarantee, no questions asked" · Welcome Kit with "FREE Frother (Value \$30)" · Free shipping over \$49
Repeated themes	"#1" · fruiting-body purity · mold and toxin testing · taste superiority · category-founder status
Vs coffee	Coffee upgrade. "The coffee that started the mushroom coffee movement 10 years ago."
Caffeine	~50mg. "About half the caffeine of a regular cup."

Two things only Four Sigmatic does: it is the only brand with named celebrity endorsers, and the only one that **attacks a named rival's taste** ("No MUD Taste").

OBSERVED inconsistency: Four Sigmatic states both "400M+ Cups Served" and "Over 200 Million cups served" on different pages of its own site.

7.2 MUD\WTR — the anti-coffee position

Promise	"Fuel For Your Mind & Body" · "Better than coffee" · "#1 Coffee Alternative" · "Clean energy without the crash" · "Focus without the jitters" · "focused and alert during the day, while allowing you to access deep sleep"
Mechanism	The most transparent dosing of the six. Full per-serving mg published: Lion's Mane 560mg, Chaga 560mg, Reishi 560mg, Cordyceps 560mg, Cacao 2,000mg, Masala Chai 750mg, Turmeric 420mg. Stated total "2,240mg of Mushrooms" per serving. Explicit ingredient-to-benefit mapping. L-theanine + low caffeine as the named anti-jitter mechanism.
Proof	"Over 60,000 Verified Five Star Reviews" · "Over 240 Million Cups Served" · "USDA Certified Organic," "Whole30 Approved" · GAP: no press logos found
Offer	\$1.66/serving one-time, \$1.33 subscription, \$1.11 bulk · "43% OFF STARTER KITS" · 30-day money back guarantee · Free frother, free book, free US shipping
Repeated themes	Caffeine benchmarking against Starbucks by name · ritual language · sleep preservation · the cacao-chai joke, in three variants
Vs coffee	Coffee replacement, aggressively. "We weren't mad at coffee, just disappointed." "JUST SAY YES, TO COFFEE ON MUSHROOMS." It contains no coffee at all — it uses black tea.
Caffeine	35mg. "For reference, a 12oz Starbucks Pikes Place has 235mg of caffeine."

The move nobody else makes: MUD\WTR runs a live ad titled **"The difference between MUD and Mushroom Coffee."** It is positioned against coffee and against mushroom coffee simultaneously.

OBSERVED inconsistency: the same MUD\WTR page displays "Over 40k 5-Star Reviews" and "116,053 reviews · Rated 4.4 out of 5 stars." The homepage says 60,000+.

7.3 EVERYDAY DOSE — the collagen differentiator and RYZE's closest ad-level rival

Promise	"Mushroom Coffee for Focus and Immunity + Free Starter Kit" · "Calm, all-day focus with zero jitters and no crash " · "No 2pm crash" · " Calms cortisol " · "Skin hydration, strong hair/nails, and joint comfort"
Mechanism	Collagen + L-theanine as co-stars alongside mushrooms — the only brand of the six to do this. "Hydrolyzed Bovine Collagen Peptides, Coffee, L-Theanine, Organic Chaga, Organic Lion's Mane." Proprietary blend totals published (7,300mg / 8,700mg) but not per-ingredient . "100% fruiting body." "Double Extracted." Note the hedged verb: collagen " may help support healthy joints."
Proof	"4.9 · 100k+" on the homepage, **"4.8
Offer	\$29 (from \$45), \$0.96/cup · 60-serving sub \$49, \$0.82/cup · 45-day guarantee , " Love it or your money back " · Gift stack itemised to " +\$100 Value " including a "Breathwork App by Othership (\$65 value)"
Repeated themes	"zero jitters" · "No 2pm crash" · lab testing · risk reversal · the "+" naming convention (Coffee+, Matcha+, Creamer+)
Vs coffee	Coffee upgrade. Their clearest line: "Normal coffee might give you a short boost of energy, but it's often followed by jitters, crash, poor sleep, or stomach problems. Everyday Dose keeps everything you know and love about coffee (taste, ritual) without all the side effects."
Caffeine	Tiered by SKU: 45mg Mild, 90mg Medium , 40mg Matcha+ — letting the buyer self-select while still promising zero jitters, with L-theanine as the reconciling mechanism.

Why Everyday Dose matters most for this case study: its live Meta hook is "**Pour Yourself Coffee That Does More** 🍵" while RYZE's is "**Pour Yourself a Better Cup of Coffee** 🍵" — the same construction, the same emoji, running on the same day. See Section 8.

7.4 LAIRD SUPERFOOD — the full-caffeine outlier

Promise	"CLEAN ENERGY, EVERY DAY." · "From sunrise to surf — clean, sustained energy made from real food." · "This is coffee unleashed."
Mechanism	"We supercharge our delicious roast by adding organic extracts from functional mushrooms, including Chaga, Lion's Mane, Maitake, and Cordyceps." "approximately 500 mg of our mushroom blend per serving" — the lowest disclosed dose of the six, roughly a quarter of MUD\WTR's. Only brand including Maitake. Ground and whole-bean coffee, not instant powder.
Proof	"44k+ Five Star Reviews" homepage · "4.8777504 / 5 from 818 reviews" on the PDP · "Loved by 12,357 people and counting!" · Non-GMO Verified, Gluten Free · GAP: no press logos, no clinical claims, and notably no third-party testing language at all
Offer	\$20.00 , 12oz bag · 30-day money back guarantee · Free shipping for new customers · GAP: servings per bag and cost per serving are not published — the only brand of the six not to state one
Repeated themes	"clean energy" · "real food" · surf and outdoor-athlete world · "No B.S."
Vs coffee	Coffee upgrade, most coffee-loyal of the six. The coffee is the hero; the mushrooms are the additive. No anti-coffee language anywhere.
Caffeine	~100mg — full strength, and unapologetic. Roughly 2× Four Sigmatic and ~3× MUD\WTR.

The most useful single observation about Laird: it is **the only brand of the six that makes no jitter claim at all**, and it is the only full-caffeine product. Those two facts are the same fact. A brand cannot promise "no jitters" while selling 100mg of caffeine, so it does not try.

Ad-level caveat, OBSERVED: of Laird's 46 active US ads, the creatives observed promote creamers, hydration, protein bars and greens — **not mushroom coffee**. Laird is a broad superfood brand that happens to sell mushroom coffee.

7.5 RASA — the zero-caffeine, calm-led position

Promise	"Calmer Than Coffee" · "Rasa is what happens when an herbalist makes your coffee." · "energy is supposed to be calm" · "Enjoy in the morning or afternoon without disrupting your sleep" · "no 2 pm crash"
Mechanism	The most specific mg disclosure of the six. Chicory 2419mg, Burdock 1200mg, Shatavari 994mg, Dandelion 600mg, Eleuthero 600mg, Codonopsis 600mg, Maca 300mg, Ashwagandha 75mg, Rhodiola 56mg, Chaga 19mg, Reishi 19mg. "Herbalist-formulated to combine the best of Ayurvedic, Chinese, & Western herbalism."
Proof	Per-SKU review counts (Original 2,301) · "85% 5-star ratings" · the only brand of the six displaying no numeric star rating · "USDA ORGANIC," "3RD PARTY LAB TESTED" · GAP: no press logos, no clinical claims, and "an herbalist" is never named
Offer	\$29.99 / 8oz, 30 servings, ~\$1.00 per serving · "SUBSCRIBE & SAVE 20%" · Guarantee: "Unopened bag? Within 60 days of your order, we'll take it back."
Repeated themes	"calm energy" · herbalism lineage · sleep protection · full-dose transparency
Vs coffee	Coffee replacement, positioned on calm rather than function.
Caffeine	"OMG CAFFEINE" — the only true zero-caffeine product of the six. Caffeine removal is the mechanism.

Two things worth flagging, both OBSERVED:

- Rasa's guarantee is the narrowest of the six — 60 days but conditional on the bag being unopened. That is not a try-it-and-see guarantee. Compare Four Sigmatic's "60-day, no questions asked."
- Despite "We pack your mug with mushrooms," Rasa's actual mushroom content is 19mg chaga + 19mg reishi = 38mg — against MUD\WTR's stated 2,240mg. Rasa is adaptogen-led, not mushroom-led. It also uses chaga mycelium, while three competitors explicitly claim fruiting-body only.

7.6 Cross-competitor summary

WHAT MOST COMPETITORS SAY

Five of six promise energy and focus without the jitters or the crash, delivered by lion's mane for focus and chaga for immunity, at reduced caffeine, with six-figure five-star review counts as proof and a free frother in the box.

That sentence is, near enough, the entire category.

WHAT IS SATURATED

SATURATED ELEMENT	EXTENT
"without the jitters" / "no jitters"	5 of 6 brands, verbatim
"no crash"	4 of 6 — and Everyday Dose and Rasa independently use the near-identical "2pm crash" / "2 pm crash"
"clean energy"	3 of 6
Simultaneous "#1" claims	4 of 6, in overlapping categories. Four Sigmatic "#1 Mushroom Coffee Brand", MUD\WTR "#1 Coffee Alternative", Rasa "#1 in Functional Adaptogens", Everyday Dose "Best Mushroom Coffee". All four are #1.
Lion's mane → focus, chaga → immunity	6 of 6
Free frother	3 of 6 — a table stake, not a differentiator

WHAT PROOF STYLES REPEAT

- **Six-figure five-star review counts** — four of six cluster on the "40k to 100k+ five-star" formulation
- **"X million cups served"** — two of six, and **both are internally inconsistent on their own sites**
- **Lab-testing badges** — three of six (Laird makes no testing claim; RYZE's testing sentence is scoped to "the other ingredients")
- **USDA Organic** — four of six

WHAT IS GENUINELY RARE

RARE ELEMENT	WHO DOES IT
Disclosed-N survey statistics ("N=1,145", "NPS 9.21/10")	Everyday Dose only
Named celebrity endorsers	Four Sigmatic only
Full per-ingredient mg disclosure	MUD\WTR and Rasa only
L-theanine as the named anti-jitter mechanism	MUD\WTR and Everyday Dose only
Collagen / beauty and joint benefit axis	Everyday Dose only
A clinical trial claim	NOBODY. Not one of the six makes one.

WHAT CUSTOMERS APPEAR TO CARE ABOUT THAT COMPETITORS MAY UNDEREMPHASISE

Cross-referencing Sections 3–5 against the competitor claim set:

- **Whether cancelling is easy.** Customers rank this as their number one objection. In the competitor set it appears only as small print — MUD\WTR's "Easy to Cancel or Pause", Everyday Dose's "Cancel anytime." Nobody leads with it.
- **Whether they will personally feel anything.** Pattern 4 is a real and quiet objection. Every brand promises results; nobody addresses non-response. Everyday Dose comes closest by publishing "60% Noticed improvements in 1 month" — which is the only number in the category that implicitly concedes 40% did not.
- **How much mushroom is actually in there.** Two customers, independently, one in Spanish, ask for the quantity. Four of the six brands do not publish per-ingredient doses.
- **Serving-count honesty and bag weight.** Two Target reviewers measured. Nobody in the category makes an issue of it.
- **Taste as a real, admitted problem.** The category treats taste as a claim ("delicious", "smooth"). Customers treat it as a risk they are taking. Only Four Sigmatic acknowledges taste as a battleground, and only by attacking a rival.

08

META AD LIBRARY AUDIT

Read this framing before the findings, and put it on a slide.

The Ad Library shows you **what is running**. It does not show you spend, impressions, CTR, CPA, ROAS, or profitability. Nothing in this section proves any ad works.

Every finding below is labelled, and the "Not supported" line is included on purpose so students see the discipline modelled.

8.1 What was actually queried

Meta Ad Library API, US, 25 August 2026. Six queries: RYZE by page ID (both ACTIVE and ALL), and keyword searches for "mushroom coffee no jitters no crash", "Everyday Dose mushroom coffee", "Four Sigmatic mushroom coffee lion's mane", and "MUD WTR coffee alternative".

8.2 RYZE — the volume finding

- **OBSERVED:** RYZE Superfoods (page ID 107940537227344) shows an **estimated 13,973 active ads in the US**.
- **OBSERVED:** querying with ad_active_status = ALL returned **the identical count**, 13,973.
- **OBSERVED:** every one of the 50 ads returned was created within roughly a **24-hour window** — creation timestamps clustered between 24 Aug 2026 20:38 UTC and 24 Aug 2026 21:59 UTC, with delivery starting 25 Aug 2026 05:24–08:47 UTC. Many were created within the same 81 minutes.
- **OBSERVED:** only **three distinct ad titles** appear across all 50: "Feel Better with RYZE 🍄", "Pour Yourself a Better Cup of Coffee 🍄", and the Spanish "Pruebalo ahora! 🍄".

INFERENCE (labelled): the API appears to return newest-first, and RYZE appears to be refreshing creative in very large same-day batches. Consistent with the timestamps.

Not supported: that 13,973 ads means 13,973 different creatives. It does not. In Meta's structure, one creative duplicated across many ad sets or placements produces many ad IDs. Ad count is not creative count.

Not supported: that any of these ads is performing. No performance data exists here.

A hard limitation, stated honestly: because every returned result is from the last 24 hours and ALL returns the same count as ACTIVE, **this tool could not measure RYZE ad longevity at all**. The 3 Signals framework has three legs — longevity, repetition, recency — and on this pass only two of

them were readable. Longevity would require the browser Ad Library UI with its "Started running on" dates, filtered and sorted by hand. That is a collection task, and it goes in Section 11.

8.3 The message repetition finding

- **OBSERVED:** across three days of RYZE ads, the message set collapses to two English propositions — feel better and pour a better cup of coffee — plus one Spanish CTA.
- **OBSERVED:** RYZE is running **Spanish-language creative in the US market** ("Pruebalo ahora! 🍷"), created in the same batch as the English.

INFERENCE (labelled): the concentration on two English messages, run at this volume, suggests conviction in those two propositions. Reasonable. Also consistent with a lazy account, a template-driven build, or an automated creative pipeline. **The read and its failure modes both have to be taught.**

8.4 The near-identical hook — the single best Ad Library artefact in this pack

OBSERVED, both active on 25 August 2026:

BRAND	AD TITLE	PAGE ID
RYZE Superfoods	"Pour Yourself a Better Cup of Coffee 🍷"	107940537227344
Everyday Dose	"Pour Yourself Coffee That Does More 🍷"	102454544917397

Same verb, same opening three words, same object, same emoji, same day, same market, same category.

OBSERVED Everyday Dose's active set is even more concentrated than RYZE's — of ~30 returned results, essentially every one carried the identical title "Pour Yourself Coffee That Does More 🍷".

INFERENCE (labelled): two well-funded brands independently converged on the same hook construction. This is what claim saturation looks like at the creative level, and it corroborates the Stage 4 diagnosis in Section 6.3 from a completely different evidence source. **Not supported:** that either brand copied the other. We have no such evidence, and the more likely explanation is that both arrived at the same place from the same market conditions.

8.5 Competitor ad presence

BRAND	ACTIVE US ADS OBSERVED	OBSERVED AD TITLES
RYZE Superfoods	~13,973 est.	"Feel Better with RYZE 🍷" · "Pour Yourself a Better Cup of Coffee 🍷" · "Pruebalo ahora! 🍷"
Everyday Dose	high volume, single dominant title	"Pour Yourself Coffee That Does More 🍷"
MUD\WTR	56	"Get 43% Off" · "Get 43% Off Your Starter Kit" · "Get started for \$29" · "Try MUD\WTR Now" · "Over 25,000 5-star Reviews" · "The #1 Coffee Alternative" · "A Coffee Alternative" · "\$20 off + free frother 🍷"
Laird Superfood	46	Creamers, hydration, protein bars, greens. No mushroom coffee creative observed.
Om Mushroom	3 , all one creative	"Set Your Standard."
Four Sigmatic	Zero brand-owned ads surfaced in the query run	—

OBSERVED, the sharpest structural contrast in the whole audit:

- **RYZE** runs ~14,000 ads on **two English messages**, refreshed in same-day batches.
- **MUD\WTR** runs **56 ads across at least eight distinct messages**, with creation dates spanning **14 to 25 August 2026** — a visible spread rather than a single batch.

INFERENCE (labelled): these are two fundamentally different account philosophies — extreme volume on few messages versus modest volume on many messages. Reasonable given the counts and timestamps. **Not supported:** that either approach is more profitable. There is no performance data here, and Forbes' 3% EBITDA figure is the only profitability signal in this entire pack.

OBSERVED and worth its own note: MUD\WTR's ad titles are almost entirely **offer-led** — "43% Off", "\$29", "\$20 off + free frother", plus one proof-led title ("Over 25,000 5-star Reviews"). RYZE's are entirely **benefit-led** with no price in the title. Two different bets about what the click is bought with.

8.6 The affiliate and arbitrage layer

This is the finding a student would miss and should not.

- **OBSERVED:** searching category terms surfaces a large population of pages that are **not brands at all**: "Mushroom Coffee's Ranked", "The Better Morning Club", "Neubrain", "Coffee We Love", "Coffee Fanatics", "Micah and Sarah", "Dr. Liza Davis", "Health Hacks Club".
- **OBSERVED, their hooks:** "Would Your Life Improve If You Never Get Burnout Ever Again? 🔥" (run by at least three different pages, identical wording) · "I Tested Them All. One Won. ➡️" · "See how I rank them" · "Get 20% Off & Free Gifts For Life! 🔥" · "Your morning coffee, upgraded 🍵 ✨" · "The #1 Cacao for Brain Health"
- **OBSERVED:** searching "Four Sigmatic mushroom coffee lion's mane" returned **289 estimated results and zero Four Sigmatic-owned ads**. Every result was an affiliate or arbitrage page.
- **OBSERVED:** the identical creative "Would Your Life Improve If You Never Get Burnout Ever Again? 🔥" runs simultaneously from multiple unrelated page names.

INFERENCE (labelled): a meaningful share of this category's Meta surface is affiliate and advertorial traffic rather than brand traffic, and the dominant affiliate format is the **ranking or comparison listicle**. Reasonable across multiple independent pages and hooks. **Not supported:** any claim about how much of the category's revenue this represents.

Why this matters for the search-reputation finding: Section 2.12 established that the page ranking #2 for "ryze mushroom coffee scam" carries affiliate links and a discount code. The Ad Library shows the same economy operating in paid. **The comparison content a skeptical buyer seeks out is substantially produced by people paid on the purchase.** Two independent evidence sources, same conclusion.

8.7 Ad Library limits, stated for the classroom

- **OBSERVED:** the API returns ad link titles and snapshot URLs, **not full primary-text bodies**. Every verbatim ad body requires opening the snapshot URL by hand.
- **OBSERVED:** keyword search is noisy. "mushroom coffee no jitters no crash" returned an estimated **34,905** results including nicotine pouches, liver supplements, romance fiction and audio drama apps. Estimated counts on broad keywords measure keyword overlap, not category size.
- **OBSERVED:** ad_active_status = ALL returned the same count as ACTIVE for RYZE, so inactive-ad history was not readable through this route.
- **The honest summary:** on this pass, **recency and repetition were readable; longevity was not.**

09

POSSIBLE WHITE SPACE

The standard applied to each territory, all three legs required:

- Customers demonstrably care about it — with quotes
- Competitors appear to underuse it — with competitor evidence
- RYZE can credibly support it — with a product or business truth

"Nobody is saying this" is not sufficient. Two territories were rejected on exactly that basis and are listed at the end.

TERRITORY 1

Transaction confidence

Customer evidence: the number one objection in the entire set is not about the product. "teaser ad for a discount but had to do a subscription..I don't even know if I'd like it" · "It is the responsibility of the consumer to not only find this AUTO SHIP feature, but it is your responsibility to deactivate it from robbing you" · "The word 'cancel' is nowhere on their site even when you do a Ctrl+F search" · "I love the product, but... they don't allow it!"

Competitor/category evidence: across all six brands audited, cancellation appears only as small print — "Easy to Cancel or Pause", "Cancel anytime". **No brand in this category leads with transaction confidence.** Guarantees are used for product risk, never purchase-mechanism risk.

RYZE product truth: RYZE already offers a 30-day money-back guarantee and states "Adjust Shipments or Cancel Anytime." The claim infrastructure exists.

Why it may matter: the top organic result for "ryze mushroom coffee scam" is the BBB complaints page. The objection is already on page one of Google for anyone who looks. It is being handled by silence.

Confidence: MODERATE, and deliberately not higher. The customer evidence is overwhelming and the competitor gap is real. But this territory has a hard prerequisite that is not a messaging problem: **918 BBB complaints in three years say the underlying experience would have to change first.** A claim of transaction confidence made against that record would fail on contact and would likely make the reputation worse. This is an operations finding that happens to have a messaging implication, and it must be presented in that order.

TERRITORY 2

Honest dosage and testing transparency

Customer evidence: "Me gustaria que en los ingredientes detallen la cantidad de hongos que lleva, **pero no lo dice**" (Thingtesting, Spanish) · "It's just coffee with mushrooms in it... **The mushrooms are there for filler**" (Polk Audio Forum) · "ryze doesn't even really have medicinal mushrooms" (unattributed Reddit-scraper page — **flagged as untraceable, see Section 11**)

Competitor/category evidence: only two of six brands publish per-ingredient milligram doses (MUD\WTR at 2,240mg total, Rasa with a full line-item table). Three of six make third-party testing claims. Everyday Dose offers a Certificate of Analysis. **RYZE does none of these.** Its testing sentence is scoped to "the other ingredients", and the words "third-party", "independent lab" and "Certificate of Analysis" appear nowhere on its site.

RYZE product truth: RYZE publishes 2000mg for Dark Roast and 1000mg for Chai. **The 2000mg figure is competitive** — comparable to MUD\WTR's 2,240mg and roughly four times Laird's ~500mg. RYZE is already dosing at a level worth stating, and is not stating it consistently.

Why it may matter: the "is it filler?" doubt is present in customer language, it is the exact doubt the expert coverage amplifies ("proprietary blend... do not purchase it" — Abby Langer), and RYZE appears to have the numbers to answer it.

Confidence: MODERATE-TO-HIGH. This is the strongest of the three territories: real customer doubt, a genuine competitor gap, and a product truth that already exists. **The caveat:** the Medium Roast mushroom dose could not be confirmed at all, and the MCT-oil contradiction is unresolved. Confirm the formula before building anything on it.

TERRITORY 3

The non-responder

Customer evidence: Pattern 4. "I don't see any difference in mental clarity, energy, or gut health" · "My family and I did not notice any difference" · "The product did not improve my sleep either" · And the diagnostic line from Petra T: **"We don't get the jitters from regular coffee, so not sure about a possible difference here."**

Competitor/category evidence: every brand promises results; not one addresses non-response. The closest anyone comes is Everyday Dose publishing "60% Noticed improvements in 1 month" — a number that implicitly concedes 40% did not, and the only figure of its kind in the category.

RYZE product truth: RYZE holds a 30-day guarantee and, per Forbes, an unusually large customer base, meaning it has more non-responder data than anyone. **GAP:** we have no evidence RYZE has analysed who responds and who does not.

Why it may matter: Petra T identified her own non-response mechanism unprompted — she did not have the problem the product solves. If that generalises, the non-responder issue is partly a targeting and expectation-setting question rather than a product question.

Confidence: THIN-TO-MODERATE. The customer evidence is real but structurally under-sampled — people who feel nothing rarely write reviews — and the "why" behind non-response rests substantially on one articulate customer. Needs collection before it is load-bearing.

Territories considered and REJECTED

"Nobody talks about the afternoon." Tempting, and false. Everyday Dose and Rasa both use "2pm crash" verbatim, and Rasa explicitly sells afternoon use. Not white space.

"Nobody sells mushroom coffee to men." No customer evidence either way, and no competitor evidence. This would be inventing a segment from a gap in our own sample and calling it an opportunity. **Rejected on the standard: absence of competitor messaging is not evidence of customer demand.**

10

STRATEGIC INSIGHT SYNTHESIS

Seven insights. Same four-part structure each time, and each stops at implication.

INSIGHT 1

The objection has moved from the product to the transaction

Evidence. 918 BBB complaints closed in three years, 270 in the last twelve months. The top organic result for "ryze mushroom coffee scam" is the BBB complaints page. A fully product-aware buyer writes: "teaser ad for a discount but had to do a subscription..I don't even know if I'd like it."

Pattern. Across BBB, ComplaintsBoard, Thingtesting, TikTok and forums, the same mechanics recur — unwanted enrolment, a hidden cancel path, a final page that freezes. Independent platforms, independent years, matching detail.

Insight. For this brand, at this scale, the last question before purchase is no longer does mushroom coffee work? It is can I get out of this? The buyer has finished evaluating the category and started evaluating the company.

Strategic implication. Any future strategy that treats the product claim as the main persuasion job is solving a question the market has already moved past. The binding constraint sits in the purchase mechanism, not the message. That makes it an operations question with a messaging consequence, in that order.

Evidence strength: STRONG.

INSIGHT 2

The product reputation and the company reputation have separated

Evidence. "I love the product, but unfortunately... they don't allow it!" · "Its a shame because the product was good. Now I have no interest in purchasing their product again." · "they have a decent product... It's their shady business practices that make them intolerable."

Pattern. People holding both positions in a single sentence, across three independent platforms.

Insight. RYZE is losing customers the product worked for. This is not a satisfaction problem or a quality problem. It is churn manufactured by the buying mechanism.

Strategic implication. The retention ceiling is being set by something other than the product, which means product improvement cannot lift it. It also means the most valuable existing asset — a base of people the product genuinely worked for — is being converted into the loudest public detractors.

Evidence strength: STRONG.

INSIGHT 3

The category's claim vocabulary is exhausted

Evidence. Five of six brands use "without the jitters" verbatim. Four of six claim "#1" simultaneously in overlapping categories. All six use lion's mane for focus and chaga for immunity. RYZE runs "Pour Yourself a Better Cup of Coffee ☕" on the same day Everyday Dose runs "Pour Yourself Coffee That Does More ☕". Affiliate pages run ranking hooks — "I Tested Them All. One Won."

Pattern. Independent convergence on identical language, at the page level and at the ad level, confirmed by two separate evidence sources — competitor sites and the Ad Library.

Insight. The market is Stage 4. Claims no longer separate brands, because every brand makes the same one. Ranking content exists because buyers genuinely cannot tell the options apart.

Strategic implication. Message-level differentiation in this category is largely spent. What remains available is mechanism specificity, proof style, offer structure, and trust — the things four of six competitors are still leaving mostly untouched.

Evidence strength: STRONG.

INSIGHT 4

The buying trigger is a body event, and RYZE's biggest claim has no trigger

Evidence. "the dr eliminated regular coffee from my way" · "the jitters I had been getting was making things difficult" · "I'm always super fatigued, regardless of how much sleep I get" · "I was put on anxiety medication... This however only left me tired and foggy in the mornings."

Against that: RYZE leads with a six-benefit stack including **immune health and antioxidant support**, and **neither appears in any collected customer statement as a reason to buy**.

Pattern. Every richly described purchase moment in the set is a body event or a routine disruption. None is an immunity concern.

Insight. Purchase happens when something breaks. Benefits that map onto a breakage — jitters, gut, sleep, anxiety — carry a moment. Benefits that do not — immunity, antioxidants — appear to function as permission and reassurance rather than motivation.

Strategic implication. The benefit stack may be doing two different jobs that are currently presented as one, and the evidence suggests only part of it is doing acquisition work. Worth separating before deciding what leads anywhere.

Evidence strength: MODERATE-TO-STRONG. The customer language is strong; the conclusion about why immunity is absent is an inference.

INSIGHT 5

Non-response is a targeting artefact, not only a product artefact

Evidence. Petra T: "My family and I did not notice any difference... **We don't get the jitters from regular coffee, so not sure about a possible difference here.**" Kat H: "I'm always super fatigued, regardless of how much sleep I get" — she reports no result. Harvard Health: "None of that research was conducted on mushroom coffee."

Pattern. Several people who report feeling nothing did not have the specific problem the product addresses, or had a problem far larger than a beverage.

Insight. Some non-response is a mismatch between who bought and what the product does. A person without coffee jitters cannot detect the removal of coffee jitters.

Strategic implication. Some of the "it did nothing" reputation may be generated by acquiring people the product was never going to work for. That is a targeting and expectation question before it is a formulation question. It also means non-response volume could rise as the brand scales into broader, less self-selected audiences — which is exactly what a 1,900-store Target launch does.

Evidence strength: MODERATE. The insight rests substantially on one unusually self-aware customer, supported by a handful of others.

INSIGHT 6

RYZE is dosed competitively and communicates as though it is not

Evidence. RYZE publishes 2000mg mushroom blend for Dark Roast. MUD\WTR publishes 2,240mg. Laird publishes ~500mg. Rasa's actual mushroom content is 38mg. Meanwhile RYZE's only testing sentence reads "**The other ingredients** are sourced from the best suppliers... tested for mycotoxins and heavy metals" — grammatically excluding the mushrooms. No COA. No third-party language. Medium Roast dose unconfirmed. And a customer, in Spanish, asks for exactly this: "Me gustaria que en los ingredientes detallan la cantidd de hongos que lleva, pero no lo dice."

Pattern. Doubt about mushroom content shows up in customer language, in expert criticism ("proprietary blend... do not purchase it"), and in what competitors disclose that RYZE does not.

Insight. RYZE appears to have a substantiation asset it is not using, while carrying the substantiation doubt anyway. It is paying the cost of opacity without the benefit of it.

Strategic implication. Closing a disclosure gap is cheaper than inventing a differentiator, and this one is already competitive on the numbers. **But the MCT contradiction, the three conflicting organic claims and the unconfirmed Medium Roast dose have to be resolved first.** A transparency position built on an ingredient list the brand contradicts elsewhere on its own site would be worse than silence.

Evidence strength: MODERATE-TO-STRONG on the disclosure gap. THIN on the Medium Roast dose, which is unconfirmed.

INSIGHT 7

The company's economics and its reputation problem are the same story

Evidence. Forbes: revenue from \$120,000 in 2020 to more than \$300 million in 2025, up 50% year over year, at an **estimated 3% EBITDA margin**. An unnamed investor: "**growth at all costs**" and "We saw some tactics we wouldn't employ." Alongside: 918 BBB complaints, a headline discount confined by fine print to the first delivery, an expired countdown timer offering to extend itself, and unrendered template variables sitting in the legal disclosure.

Pattern. Every observed friction points the same direction — toward maximising first orders and minimising exits.

Insight. The subscription complaints and the margin structure are not two separate findings. A business converting nearly all gross profit into acquisition depends on the recurring order, which makes the subscription the economic engine and cancellation the leak. The complaint pattern is what that pressure looks like from the customer's side.

Strategic implication. This reframes the billing issue from a customer-service failure to a structural one. It also sets a realistic ceiling on what any future strategy work can fix: messaging cannot resolve a tension that lives in the business model. Any recommendation that ignores this is recommending into a constraint it has not acknowledged.

Evidence strength: MODERATE. Both facts are solidly sourced. The causal link between them is **inference**, clearly labelled, and Forbes does not draw it.

11

RESEARCH GAPS

What this research still cannot answer, why it matters, and exactly what to collect next.

GAP 1 — Zero Reddit evidence Why it matters: Reddit is where unsold, unincentivised skepticism lives, and it is the only room where nobody is selling. Several plausible segments (nootropics, ADHD, menopause, chronic fatigue) surfaced as single scattered mentions and could not be confirmed. Our skepticism sample is drawn almost entirely from complaint platforms, which over-represent the already-burned. Collect next: manual browser passes on r/Supplements, r/Coffee, r/nootropics, r/Biohackers, r/loseit, r/Menopause. Search "ryze", "mushroom coffee", "ryze vs". Target 30+ verbatim quotes with thread URLs. **Do not use scraper mirrors** — three quotes in the raw collection came from an SEO scraper page with no usernames, subreddits or dates, and were excluded from this pack for exactly that reason.

GAP 2 — Zero Amazon reviews Why it matters: Amazon is the highest-volume comparison-shopper review pool in the US and it is where the **3-star tradeoff review** lives. Our 3-star coverage is genuinely thin — Target shows 1% at 3 stars, and we retrieved perhaps three or four honest tradeoff accounts in total. The Star Split cannot be run properly without the middle. Collect next: Amazon RYZE listings, browser, filtered to **3-star only, then 2-star**. 20 reviews minimum from each. Then the same for Four Sigmatic and Everyday Dose for comparison.

GAP 3 — Zero YouTube comments Why it matters: Video titles alone tell us the reputation landscape ("Expert Tries Ryze Mushroom Coffee (Scam)", "Mushroom Coffee by Ryze Review: A Doctor's Honest Opinion") but the comment sections underneath are where real-time skepticism gets raised in front of other buyers. This is the single richest free source in the category and we have none of it. Collect next: open each of the 14 identified video URLs, sort comments by Top, collect 10 per video, and record which videos are sponsored versus independent.

GAP 4 — Zero Trustpilot data Why it matters: Trustpilot ranks on page one for "ryze mushroom coffee review", meaning prospects see it. We cannot report its TrustScore or star distribution. Collect next: the TrustScore, full star distribution, and 15 reviews across the spectrum.

GAP 5 — Ad longevity was never measured Why it matters: longevity is one of the three legs of the 3 Signals framework, and it is the one that indicates sustained investment. Without it, this audit read recency and repetition and guessed at nothing else. Collect next: the browser Ad Library UI at facebook.com/ads/library, RYZE page, US, sorted and read for "Started running on" dates. Identify the ten longest-running ads. Repeat for Everyday Dose and MUD\WTR.

GAP 6 — No verbatim ad body copy Why it matters: the API returns ad link titles only. Every claim inside a RYZE or competitor ad is currently unknown to us, which means the strongest possible saturation evidence is uncollected. Collect next: open 20 RYZE ad snapshot URLs and 20 Everyday Dose ones. Transcribe primary text verbatim. Note format — static, UGC, founder, testimonial, before/after.

GAP 7 — Ad comment sections, entirely uncollected Why it matters: Section 2.12 shows that the billing objection ranks first on Google. Whether it also appears under RYZE's own live ads is unknown, and that is where a prospect meets it at the moment of consideration. This is the single highest-value uncollected source in the whole project. Collect next: open the live ads on Facebook and Instagram, sort by Top comments, collect 30 verbatim, and specifically note whether and how the brand replies.

GAP 8 — RYZE's Terms of Sale and refund policy are unreadable Why it matters: the entire /policies/ directory is robots-blocked. We cannot confirm the auto-renewal consent language, any cancellation cut-off, whether the guarantee covers opened bags or renewal shipments, or whether it is limited to first-time buyers. One customer quotes a "48 hours before your rebill date" condition that appears on no reachable public page. Collect next: open the policy pages in a normal browser and transcribe the auto-renewal, cancellation and refund sections verbatim.

GAP 9 — The Medium Roast formula is unresolved Why it matters: Insight 6 and White Space Territory 2 both rest on RYZE's dosage being competitive, and the flagship SKU's mushroom dose is unconfirmed. Separately, MCT oil is claimed in body copy and absent from the ingredient list. Bag weight is published nowhere. Collect next: photograph the physical bag's Supplement Facts panel and net weight. That one photograph resolves three open questions.

GAP 10 — No non-buyer evidence at all Why it matters: every single person quoted in this pack bought, nearly bought, or reacted to an ad. The people who saw the ad and scrolled past left no record anywhere. Section 5.6 — what customers need to believe before buying — is entirely reverse-engineered from post-purchase language, and it is labelled as such. Collect next: ad comment sections from people who did not buy, "why I didn't buy" threads, and — for a real client — the brand's own abandoned-cart survey and support inbox.

GAP 11 — The weight-loss buyer is a hole Why it matters: RYZE runs a weight-loss page on a subdomain that ranks on weight-loss queries, and the NAD examined a GLP-1-comparison implication for Matcha. That is significant brand-side investment in a motivation with **almost no customer evidence in our set** — one statement mentioning "decreased hunger". Either we failed to collect where those buyers talk, or the brand is marketing into a desire its customers do not voice back. Both are consequential and we cannot tell which. Collect next: search reviews and forums specifically for weight, appetite, bloating and GLP-1 language. Read the RYZE weight-loss subdomain in full.

GAP 12 — Proportion is unknowable from this evidence Why it matters: this is the methodological gap and the most important one to say out loud. We can say the billing complaint recurs; we cannot say what share of customers experience it. 918 complaints against a customer base Forbes implies is very large may be a small percentage or a large one. **Every complaint platform selects for complaints.** Collect next: nothing available publicly can close this. For a real client it is answered by their own churn rate, refund rate, chargeback rate and support-ticket categories. **State the limit rather than implying a proportion.**

One structural note for the PH classroom. These twelve gaps are US-shaped. On a Philippine brand the same gaps appear in different rooms: Shopee and Lazada instead of Amazon, TikTok Shop reviews instead of Trustpilot, Facebook group threads instead of Reddit, and the client's Messenger inbox instead of a support-ticket export. The method is identical. Only the addresses change.

12

TEACHING SHORTLIST

The best single example of each concept, with enough context for an instructor to teach it cold from a slide.

BEST OBSERVED → PATTERN → INFERENCE → GAP

The subscription complaint.

- **OBSERVED:** one BBB complaint, 22 June 2026 — "On the final page when you hit submit it freezes. Its happened on my phone and 2 different laptops at different locations and different weeks."
- **PATTERN:** three more people, on three different platforms, describe the same failure. Plus "six to seven screens", plus "dark patterns", plus "The word 'cancel' is nowhere on their site even when you do a Ctrl+F search." 918 BBB complaints in three years.
- **INFERENCE:** the cancellation flow appears designed to create friction. Reasonable. **Not proven** — a genuinely broken final page would look identical from the outside.
- **GAP:** we cannot say what percentage of customers hit this. Complaint sites only collect complaints.

Why this is the teaching example: all four rungs, one topic, and the inference is genuinely arguable rather than obvious. When a student says "so it's a scam", the answer is: you observed friction, you inferred intent, and you have no evidence for intent. Label it and move on.

BEST PAIN

"I suffer from nighttime brain chatter. It prevents me from getting restful sleep on a nightly basis. Typically I struggle to fall asleep and wake up in the early morning hours unable to get back to sleep. **It has impacted my life and ability to carry out my day to day tasks at work.**" — Antonio E, ComplaintsBoard, 7 Oct 2025

Teach: "nighttime brain chatter" is a phrase no marketer wrote. It is more specific than "insomnia" and more usable than "poor sleep." And notice the second half — he names the cost at work. That is Surface and Stakes in one quote.

BEST DESIRE

"**Anxiety , energy and focus are the motivation behind all of this.**" — mantis, Polk Audio Forum, March 2025

Teach: this is a customer summarising the entire category's desire in six words, on an audio equipment forum, with nobody selling to him. Note the order — anxiety comes first. The brand leads with energy.

BEST TRIGGER

"A few weeks ago I was having discomfort in my stomach and **the dr eliminated regular coffee from my way**. I started looking for a healthy option and found this flavor." — Target, ★5, 17 Aug 2026

Teach: a dated, specific, external event. Not "I wanted to be healthier." A doctor said stop, and the search began that week. Ask the room: how many of your client's customers are in a specific week right now, and would you know?

BEST FAILED SOLUTION

"It even got to the point where **I was put on anxiety medication to try and solve the problem. This however only left me tired and foggy in the mornings**." — Antonio E, ComplaintsBoard

Teach: the failed solution is not a rival brand. It is prescription medication, and it failed by trading one problem for another. This is what a real failed-solution chain looks like — it does not stay inside your category.

BEST OBJECTION

"and it's not cheap, **teaser ad for a discount but had to do a subscription**..I don't even know if I'd like it" — Shellback Squid, Democratic Underground, 17 Aug 2025

Teach: this is a fully product-aware buyer talking himself out of the purchase, in public, in one line. Three objections stacked — price, subscription trap, uncertainty about liking it — and **not one of them is about whether mushroom coffee works**.

BEST PROOF

"It has helped with my digestive tract immensely, **helping me go to the restroom daily compared to weekly**." — Andrea Wentz, ComplaintsBoard

Teach: "improved digestion" is a claim. "Daily compared to weekly" is proof. The difference is that the second one is a number a stranger can picture. Ask the room to find the number in their own client's reviews.

BEST SPECIFIC CUSTOMER MOMENT

"I am 68 years old. **My daughter said I was being dramatic (LOL) when I told her the last time I cleaned my house this thoroughly was when I was about 33 years old (LOL)**." — Debbie Ellis, ComplaintsBoard

Teach: she does not say "more energy." She describes a scene with two people in it, a specific act, and a 35-year comparison. This is what "verbatim means verbatim" is protecting — summarise this into "increased energy" and everything usable is gone.

BEST BUYER SEGMENT

Segment A, "Coffee Turned On Me."

- Situation: still loves coffee, body started reacting badly
- Desire: keep the ritual, lose the side effect
- Trigger: a body signal, sometimes a doctor
- Previous attempts: cutting back, switching to tea
- Objection: will low caffeine actually do the job?
- Proof need: someone with the same reaction saying it stopped
- Anchor quote: **"I still needed my boost but the jitters I had been getting was making things difficult"**
- 15+ quotes

Teach the Persona Test on it. Different reason from Segment B (gut) and Segment C (upgrade)? Yes — she is protecting a ritual, not fixing digestion, and not optimising. Would the ad be different? Yes. Five quotes minimum? Fifteen. Passes.

Then teach the rejection. "The weight-loss buyer" was cut with one customer statement. RYZE markets it heavily. Marketing it is not evidence that customers want it.

BEST AWARENESS EXAMPLE

"For about nine months, I went back and forth, debating whether to give this product a try after seeing all the buzz from social media and TV ads." — Christa Carson, ComplaintsBoard

Teach: Product-Aware, and stuck there for nine months. She knew the brand, saw the ads repeatedly, and did not buy. What she was missing was not information. Ask the room: what would have moved her in month two, and is your account currently building for people in month seven?

BEST SOPHISTICATION EXAMPLE

The saturation table. Five of six brands use "without the jitters" **verbatim**. Four of six claim to be **"#1 at the same time**, in overlapping categories: "#1 Mushroom Coffee Brand", "#1 Coffee Alternative", "#1 in Functional Adaptogens", "Best Mushroom Coffee."

Teach: put those four "#1" claims on one slide with the brand names attached. That single slide is what Stage 4 looks like. Nobody wrote a bad claim. They all wrote the same claim.

Then add the customer line that proves the market noticed: "It's just coffee with mushrooms in it...**The mushrooms are there for filler.**"

BEST COMPETITOR PROMISE / MECHANISM / PROOF / OFFER COMPARISON

Laird Superfood versus MUD\WTR — because the contrast explains itself.

	MUD\WTR	LAIRD SUPERFOOD
Promise	"Focus without the jitters"	"CLEAN ENERGY, EVERY DAY." — no jitter claim anywhere
Mechanism	35mg caffeine + l-theanine, 2,240mg mushrooms , full mg table published	~100mg caffeine , ~500mg mushrooms, ground coffee not instant
Proof	"Over 240 Million Cups Served", Whole30 Approved	"44k+ Five Star Reviews" — no testing claim at all
Offer	\$1.11–\$1.66/serving, 30-day guarantee, free frother	\$20/bag, 30-day guarantee, no serving count published

Teach: ask the room why Laird makes no jitter claim, before revealing the caffeine row. The answer is that it can't — at 100mg the claim would collapse on first use. **A competitor's silence is often a constraint, not an oversight.** That is the sophisticated read of a competitor audit.

BEST AD LIBRARY INFERENCE EXAMPLE

The RYZE volume finding, stated the correct way:

- **Observed:** the RYZE Superfoods page shows an estimated 13,973 active US ads. Every one of the 50 sampled was created within a single 24-hour window, many within the same 81 minutes. Only three distinct ad titles appear.
- **Inference:** RYZE appears to refresh creative in very large same-day batches and appears to concentrate on two English messages.
- **Not supported:** that these are 13,973 different creatives. That any of them works. That volume indicates success.
- **And the honest limitation:** ad_active_status = ALL returned the same count as ACTIVE, and every result was from the last 24 hours, so **longevity could not be measured on this pass at all.** Two of the three signals were readable. One was not.

Teach: this is the discipline slide. Most students would open the Ad Library, see 13,973, and say "RYZE is crushing it." The correct sentence is "RYZE is running a lot of ads on two messages, and I cannot see whether any of them work." Then teach the failure modes: high volume can mean conviction, or a template pipeline, or an unmanaged account.

BEST WHITE SPACE EXAMPLE

Territory 2, dosage and testing transparency — because it is the only one that passes all three legs cleanly.

- **Customers care:** two independent customers, one writing in Spanish, ask for mushroom quantities. A forum poster says "The mushrooms are there for filler."
- **Competitors underuse it:** only two of six publish per-ingredient mg. RYZE publishes no COA, no third-party testing language, and its one testing sentence is scoped to "the other ingredients."
- **RYZE can support it:** RYZE already publishes 2000mg for Dark Roast — comparable to MUD\WTR's 2,240mg and roughly 4× Laird's ~500mg.

Then teach the discipline of the caveat: confidence is Moderate-to-High, **not High**, because the Medium Roast dose is unconfirmed and the MCT-oil contradiction is unresolved. A transparency claim built on an ingredient list the brand contradicts elsewhere would be worse than saying nothing.

And teach the rejected one immediately after. "Nobody sells mushroom coffee to men" — no customer evidence, no competitor evidence, just an empty space. **An empty space is not an opportunity. It is an empty space.**

BEST FULL EVIDENCE → PATTERN → INSIGHT → IMPLICATION

Insight 2, "I love the product, I hate the company."

- **Evidence:** "I love the product, but unfortunately it gives me really bad headaches. I tried repeatedly to cancel my subscription but they don't allow it!" (Thingtesting)
- **Pattern:** "Its a shame because the product was good. Now I have no interest in purchasing their product again." (BBB) · "they have a decent product... **It's their shady business practices that make them intolerable.**" (Thingtesting) · Three platforms, same sentence structure.
- **Insight:** RYZE is losing customers the product worked for. The churn is manufactured by the buying mechanism, not the product.
- **Implication:** the retention ceiling is set by something product improvement cannot lift, and the brand's best asset — satisfied customers — is being converted into its loudest detractors.

Why this is the one to close the module on: it is four rungs, it uses direct customer language at every rung, the insight is not obvious from any single quote, and the implication is a business conclusion rather than a creative idea. It is exactly the shape of a strategist's finding, and it **stops before it becomes an ad.**

SOURCE APPENDIX

A. RYZE-authored sources

SOURCE	URL
Homepage	https://www.ryzesuperfoods.com/
Our Story (founder story, press quotes, mascot)	https://www.ryzesuperfoods.com/pages/our-story
Shop All (full range, bundles, pricing)	https://www.ryzesuperfoods.com/pages/shop-all
FAQ	https://www.ryzesuperfoods.com/pages/faq
Contact Us (cancellation steps, returns process, shipping conflict)	https://www.ryzesuperfoods.com/pages/contact-us
Mushroom Coffee Benefits (Dr. Blane Schilling byline)	https://www.ryzesuperfoods.com/pages/mushroom-coffee-benefits
Mushroom Coffee PDP (guarantee, pricing, bundle ladder)	https://www.ryzesuperfoods.com/products/mushroom-coffee
Dark Roast PDP (2000mg dose, organic caveat, 90mg caffeine)	https://www.ryzesuperfoods.com/products/dark-roast
Mushroom Chai PDP (1000mg dose)	https://www.ryzesuperfoods.com/products/mushroom-chai
Mushroom Chicory PDP (MCT oil, 0mg caffeine)	https://www.ryzesuperfoods.com/products/mushroom-chicory-30-servings
Paid traffic landing page (hedged claims, offer fine print, expired timer, 276,053 reviews)	https://shop.ryzesuperfoods.com/fb
Prop 65 page	https://www.ryzesuperfoods.com/pages/prop-65
Ambassador program	https://www.ryzesuperfoods.com/pages/affiliate
Founder essay, Andrée Werner, Oct 2020 ("It burns fat, reduces stress")	https://medium.com/@andreewerner/searching-for-purpose-and-better-coffee-f08d6f4277db
BLOCKED: refund policy, terms of service — entire /policies/ directory robots-disallowed	https://www.ryzesuperfoods.com/policies/refund-policy

B. Customer evidence sources

SOURCE	URL	WHAT IT GAVE
Target listing A (star mix 92/3/1/1/3, 2,214 reviews)	https://www.target.com/p/ryze-organic-medium-roast-mushroom-coffee-4-2oz/-/A-94825538	Quotes 1, 2, 4, 49
Target listing B (star mix 93/2/1/1/3, 1,946 reviews, "66% would recommend")	https://www.target.com/p/ryze-mushroom-coffee-4-2oz/-/A-95242666	Quotes 12, 22, 34, 46, 50, 52, 53, 54, 55
BBB complaints (918 in 3 yrs / 270 in 12 mos, A+ Accredited)	https://www.bbb.org/us/tx/austin/profile/coffee-and-tea/ryze-inc-0825-1000235729/complaints	Quotes 8, 9, 42, 58, 59, 60
BBB customer reviews (8,056, 4.84 avg)	https://www.bbb.org/us/tx/austin/profile/coffee-and-tea/ryze-inc-0825-1000235729/customer-reviews	Quotes 24, 27, 36, 48
Thingtesting (1,328 reviews, 4.7 avg)	https://thingtesting.com/brands/ryze/reviews	Quotes 3, 11, 15, 16, 17, 23, 30, 32, 33, 35, 37, 39, 40, 61
Thingtesting post ("The word 'cancel' is nowhere on their site")	https://thingtesting.com/brands/ryze/posts/88150643-6a34-4996-9f5b-04d107302d42	Pattern 1, Pattern 2
ComplaintsBoard (351 reviews, 96 complaints)	https://www.complaintsboard.com/ryze-superfoods-bl49631	Quotes 5, 6, 7, 19, 31, 38, 43, 44, 45, 47, 51
Democratic Underground thread	https://www.democraticunderground.com/100220568491	Quotes 10, 28, 29, 56
Polk Audio Forum, "Mushroom coffee and Anxiety"	https://forum.polkaudio.com/discussion/202095/mushroom-coffee-and-anxiety	Quotes 20, 25, 41
Polk Audio Forum, "Mushroom Coffee"	https://forum.polkaudio.com/discussion/200337/mushroom-coffee	Quote 21
Slickdeals	https://slickdeals.net/f/19351785-38-24-ryze-superfoods-mushroom-medium-roast-coffee-usda-organic-with-6-adaptogenic-mushrooms-usa-grown-instant-coffee	Quote 55
girlaword Substack	https://girlaword.substack.com/p/issue-4-mushroom-coffee-	Quotes 13, 14
fforest Substack comments	https://fforest.substack.com/p/tree-794-anxiety-4-quit-caffeine/comments	Quotes 18, 26

SOURCE	URL	WHAT IT GAVE
Walmart (4.7, 11,700 ratings, no review text served)	https://www.walmart.com/ip/17930201806	Rating only
TikTok, @joshfoodnstuff (caption via search index only; page robots-disallowed)	https://www.tiktok.com/@joshfoodnstuff/video/7480709794794458410	"They made the writing TINY and hard to find"

C. Regulatory, legal and press — verified against primary documents

SOURCE	URL	STATUS
NAD decision, Case #7492, 11 Sep 2025	https://bbbprograms.org/media/newsroom/decisions/ryze-superfoods	Verified directly
NutraIngredients on the NAD case (RYZE's statement)	https://www.nutraingredients.com/Article/2025/09/24/ryze-superfoods-drops-mushroom-coffee-and-matcha-health-claims-after-nad-inquiry/	Verified
Federal docket, Younger v. Ryze Inc., 2:24-cv-00868 — voluntary dismissal 8 Feb 2024	https://dockets.justia.com/docket/california/cacdce/2:2024cv00868/913335	Verified directly. Primary source.
TINA.org — lists the same case as "Pending"	https://truthinadvertising.org/class-action/ryze/	Verified, and it CONTRADICTS the docket
California OAG Prop 65 settlement, EHA v. RYZE LLC (\$2,000 penalty, \$20,500 fees, oats not coffee)	https://oag.ca.gov/system/files/prop65/settlements/2024-03522S5275.pdf	Primary document
Forbes, Chloe Sorvino, 9 Jan 2026 (revenue trajectory, 3% EBITDA, "growth at all costs")	https://www.forbes.com/sites/chloesorvino/2026/01/09/mushroom-coffee-maker-ryze-could-be-the-next-billion-dollar-drink-or-a-warning-of-a-bubble/	Verified

D. Independent expert assessment

SOURCE	URL
Abby Langer, RD ("not enough high-quality human evidence")	https://abbylangernutrition.com/ryze-mushroom-coffee-review-supercharge-your-health/
Harvard Health, "Mushroom coffee: Worth a taste?"	https://www.health.harvard.edu/diet-and-nutrition/mushroom-coffee-worth-a-taste
CSPI, "Do mushroom supplements live up to the hype?" (Cohen, Laszlo, per-mushroom trial data)	https://www.cspi.org/article/do-mushroom-supplements-live-hype
Cleveland Clinic, lion's mane	https://health.clevelandclinic.org/lions-mane-mushrooms-benefits
Parade, Katie Drakeford RD, 6 Nov 2025	https://parade.com/food/ryze-mushroom-coffee-review

E. Competitor sources (all competitor-authored)

Four Sigmatic: <https://us.foursigmatic.com/> · /products/original-mushroom-coffee (guarantee: "60-day money-back guarantee, no questions asked") · /pages/the-original-mushroom-coffee ("No MUD Taste", "No Caffeine Crash", "No Digestive Issues" — these appear on the collection page, **not** on the PDP) MUD\WTR: <https://mudwtr.com/> · /products/30-servings-tin · /pages/super-pdp-lp ("2,240mg of Mushrooms" and "For reference, a 12oz Starbucks Pikes Place has 235mg of caffeine" appear here; the homepage renders the Starbucks line differently as "a 12-oz Starbucks Pikes Place has around 235mg") · /pages/mushroom-coffee-alternative-rise Everyday Dose: <https://www.everydaydose.com/> · /products/30-serving-mushroom-coffee · /pages/ingredients Laird Superfood: <https://lairdsuperfood.com/> · /products/perform-medium-roast-ground-mushroom-coffee Rasa: <https://wearerasa.com/> · /products/original-rasa Root & Rise (reference only): <https://rootandrisecoffee.com/>

F. Meta Ad Library

Accessed via the Meta Ad Library API, US, active status, 25 August 2026. Six queries: RYZE by page ID 107940537227344 (ACTIVE and ALL), "mushroom coffee no jitters no crash", "Everyday Dose mushroom coffee", "Four Sigmatic mushroom coffee lion's mane", "MUD WTR coffee alternative".

Page IDs recorded: RYZE Superfoods 107940537227344 · Everyday Dose 102454544917397 · MUD\WTR 172538983355501 · Laird Superfood 1495383094086931 · Om Mushroom Superfood 120515481417161

Individual ads are inspectable at https://www.facebook.com/ads/library/?id={ad_id}. Example IDs cited: RYZE 28136342282716411, 2982448775420800 · Everyday Dose 1375529757445549 · MUD\WTR 1400456678961225, 1054096150333323.

G. Excluded on purpose

SOURCE	WHY EXCLUDED
stripe.jhu.edu/news/ryze-coffee-reddit	SEO-spam page on a university subdomain reproducing Reddit-looking content with no usernames, no subreddits, no dates, no thread links . Three quotes were retrieved from it and are not used in this pack . They are untraceable, and untraceable is not evidence.
getevident.co	Secondary review site. Two of its legal characterisations were checked against primary documents and both were wrong — it describes a dismissed case as "active" and reports a \$20,500 attorney-fee figure as a lead-exposure penalty.
soma-analytics.com	Ranks #2 for "ryze mushroom coffee scam" and "is ryze legit" while carrying affiliate links and the discount code SOMA . Cited in Section 2.12 as an artefact of the search landscape, never as evidence about the product.

Collected 25 August 2026. Every claim in this pack is traceable to a source in this appendix. Where it is not, it is labelled INFERENCE or GAP.